

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Acts 1:1-3

Here Luke summarizes his first book, the Gospel of Luke, which Luke had previously written to Theophilus ([Luke 1:3](#)). Theophilus is elsewhere called “most honorable” ([Luke 1:3](#))—the title indicates that he was a person of very high social standing (cp. [Acts 23:26](#); [24:2](#); [26:25](#)). He was probably a benefactor or patron who assisted Luke with the expenses of publication or distribution of his work (see study note on Luke 1:3).

Acts 1:3

he proved to them in many ways that he was actually alive: The Gospels describe the evidence for Christ’s resurrection: Jesus’ tomb was empty ([Luke 24:3-4](#)), his grave clothes were undisturbed ([John 20:3-9](#)), and many people saw him (see [Matt 28](#); [Mark 16:1-8](#); [Luke 24:1-53](#); [John 20:11-21:23](#); [1 Cor 15:3-8](#)). Jesus appeared to the apostles in part to overcome their doubt ([Matt 28:17](#); [Luke 24:17-24](#), [38](#), [41](#); [John 20:27](#); see [Mark 16:14](#)) • The Kingdom of God was the central theme of Jesus’ teaching (see [Acts 1:6-8](#); [Matt 4:17](#); [Mark 1:14-15](#); [Luke 4:43](#)).

Acts 1:4

until the Father sends you the gift he promised: See [2:1-13](#); cp. [John 14:15-17](#).

Acts 1:5

baptized: See “Baptism” Theme Note.

Acts 1:6-11

Jesus’ ascent into heaven (see also [Luke 24:50-53](#)) took place on the Mount of Olives ([Acts 1:12](#); [Luke 24:50](#)). It was Jesus’ last physical appearance—he was taken into heaven, where he will remain “until the time for the final restoration of all things” ([Acts 3:21](#)).

Acts 1:8

This key verse outlines the geographical extension of the Good News from its Jewish starting point in Jerusalem and Judea ([1:6-8:1](#)), out to Samaria ([8:4-25](#)), Antioch in Syria ([11:19-30](#)), and eventually throughout the Mediterranean world to Rome ([13:1-28:31](#)). Christ later gave a similar call to be his witnesses . . . to the ends of the earth to Saul of Tarsus ([9:15](#)), who had persecuted the Jewish Christians and then became the primary instrument for taking the Good News to the Gentiles. • The Holy Spirit was the source of power for all this evangelistic and missionary effort.

Acts 1:10

Christ’s rising into heaven indicates his elevation to a place of ultimate authority (see [Eph 1:19-23](#); [Phil 2:9-11](#)).

Acts 1:11

Jesus promised to return from heaven in the same way (see [Matt 24:30](#); [Mark 13:26](#); [John 14:3](#)). Jesus has gone to heaven to prepare the place for his followers ([John 12:26](#); [14:1-4](#); [2 Cor 5:4](#); [Phil 3:21](#); [Heb 6:20](#)).

Acts 1:12

The witnesses of the ascension returned to Jerusalem with joy, worship, exhilaration, and praise to God ([Luke 24:52](#)), and with their doubts assuaged (see study note on Acts 1:3).

Acts 1:13

All eleven of the remaining apostles were present (cp. [Matt 10:2-4](#); [Mark 3:16-19](#); [Luke 6:13-16](#)). Judas Iscariot is omitted from this list on account of his betrayal and death ([Acts 1:18-19](#)).

Acts 1:13–26

While the apostles waited for the promised gift of the Holy Spirit ([1:4–5](#)), the whole company of 120 disciples in Jerusalem engaged in earnest prayer ([1:13–14](#)) and then appointed an apostle to replace Judas Iscariot ([1:15–26](#)).

Acts 1:14

The first disciples were united in worship, fellowship, and prayer (see also [2:42](#), [46–47](#); [4:24–31](#); [5:12](#); [12:5](#); [13:1–3](#)). The faithful women who had been witnesses of Jesus' crucifixion and resurrection were present ([Luke 23:49](#), [54–56](#); [24:1–10](#), [22](#)). • The brothers of Jesus had not believed in him during his ministry ([John 7:3–5](#); cp. [Matt 12:46–49](#)), but became his disciples after his resurrection.

Acts 1:16–17

the Scriptures had to be fulfilled: See [1:20](#).

Acts 1:18–19

Matthew's account ([Matt 27:3–10](#)) is somewhat different; the two can be harmonized by considering the priests' purchase of the "Field of Blood" as acting in Judas's name. In addition, Judas may have committed suicide by hanging, but he subsequently fell headfirst and his body split open, perhaps when the rope broke.

Acts 1:20–21

'Let someone else take his position': It was imperative that a replacement be found for Judas so that his position as the twelfth apostle would not remain empty. The new people of God, like Israel, were to have twelve designated and appointed leaders (see [Matt 19:28](#); [Luke 22:29–30](#)).

Acts 1:21–22

To qualify for nomination as an apostle, a man had to have been with the other apostles the entire time of Jesus' public ministry, from the time he was baptized by John until his ascension.

Acts 1:23–26

With prayer ([1:14](#), [24](#)) and humble dependence on God to reveal his will, the apostles cast lots, using an established method of finding God's will (see [Lev 16:8](#); [Num 27:21](#); [Deut 33:8](#); [Josh 14:2](#); [18:3–10](#); [Prov 16:33](#)). Matthias was selected to replace Judas. After Pentecost, the Holy Spirit guided Jesus' followers through dreams, visions, and prophecies instead of through lots (cp. [Acts 2:17–18](#); [13:2](#); [16:7–10](#)). • you know every heart: See also [1 Sam 16:6–7](#); [1 Kgs 8:39](#); [1 Chr 28:9](#); [2 Chr 6:30](#); [Pss 7:9](#); [44:21](#); [Jer 11:20](#); [John 2:24–25](#); [Rev 2:23](#).

Acts 2:1–4

Jews observed three great annual pilgrimage festivals, when many would go to the Temple in Jerusalem—Unleavened Bread (which includes Passover), Pentecost (Harvest), and Shelters (see [Lev 23:1–44](#)). On Pentecost, when the Jewish people were gathered in Jerusalem to celebrate the harvest of God's blessings, and when the disciples were united and expectant as they gathered for prayer, the Holy Spirit came and filled the gathered believers.

Acts 2:4

everyone present was filled with the Holy Spirit: This event marks the coming of the Holy Spirit to fill Jesus' disciples, as he had promised, so that they could be powerful witnesses ([1:4–5](#), [8](#)). The Spirit's wisdom, energy, and power were the driving force behind the church's work and witness (e.g., [2:14–41](#), [43](#); [4:31](#); [9:17](#), [20](#); [13:9–12](#); see also [Eph 5:18](#)). • began speaking in other languages: The Holy Spirit gave extraordinary communication that made it possible for people from other countries to hear in their own languages about what God had done ([Acts 2:6–11](#)). This passage is one of several references to speaking in "other languages" or "tongues" (see also [10:44–48](#); [19:6](#); [1 Cor 14:2–28](#), [39](#)). Here, this supernatural gift reveals the energizing presence of God's Spirit and inaugurates the proclamation of the Good News to people of every nation.

Acts 2:5–11

Because Pentecost was a pilgrimage festival (see study note on 2:1–4), Jews from every nation were present in Jerusalem at that time and were thus able to hear the Good News being proclaimed in their own languages. The Good News is for all people ([2:38–39](#)).

Acts 2:9–11

Parthians came from the region stretching from the Tigris River eastward to India. Medes (now called Kurds) were from Media, east of Mesopotamia and north of the Persian Gulf. Elamites were from Elam (now in Iran), north of the Persian Gulf and just east of the Tigris River. Mesopotamia lay between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. Judea was well known as the Jewish homeland. Cappadocia, Pontus, and Asia were Roman provinces in Asia Minor (now in Turkey; see [1 Pet 1:1](#)); Paul later taught and preached in some of these areas (see [Acts 16:6; 19:10, 26](#)). Phrygia and Pamphylia were districts of Asia Minor later visited by Paul ([13:13; 18:23](#)). Egypt had a large Jewish population, particularly in the city of Alexandria (see [18:24](#)). North Africa was also represented by Libya and Cyrene. Rome was the imperial capital and the home of thousands of Jews. The Cretans came from the island of Crete, located south-southeast of Greece, and the Arabs from the area south and east of Jerusalem. • The inclusion of all of these nations suggests how the Good News was going to go out to the ends of the earth ([1:8](#)).

Acts 2:10–11

converts to Judaism: See study note on 13:43.

Acts 2:14–36

This is the first of about thirty speeches in Acts and one of the most important, standing as it does at the very inception of the church. It is a typical example of the preaching of the apostles, who proclaimed (1) that the Old Testament promises had been fulfilled in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ, who is the promised Messiah; (2) that the apostles themselves were eyewitnesses of Jesus' entire public ministry and were his chosen representatives; (3) that people are called to

repent of their sins and have faith in God through Christ; and (4) that salvation and the presence of the Holy Spirit are promised to those who respond affirmatively to this message of Good News. This basic message is echoed in the sermons of chs [3, 4, 5, 8, 10, and 13](#). The same themes characterized Paul's preaching (see [1 Cor 15:3–9](#)). This message was repeatedly preached to both Jews and Gentiles throughout the Mediterranean world; all people are summoned to repent of their sins and turn to God through faith in Jesus Christ.

Acts 2:17–21

This passage quotes [Joel 2:28–32](#). The prophet Joel predicted a wider exercise of the gifts of prophecy, including visions and dreams by both young and old, both men and women in the last days ([Joel 2:28–29](#)). In Acts, on the day of Pentecost, Peter declared that Joel's prophecy was being fulfilled, signaling that "the last days" had arrived.

Acts 2:23–28

While cruel men had crucified Jesus, this action had not defeated God's prearranged plan for salvation. In fact, God raised him back to life, which David had foretold ([2:25–28](#)).

Acts 2:27

among the dead: See study note on Matt 11:23.

Acts 2:32–36

God raised Jesus from the dead, and we are all witnesses of this: The witness theme is often repeated in Acts (e.g., [3:15; 4:33; 5:32; 10:39–43](#)). The capstone of this message is that God the Father, as he had promised, was now pouring out his Holy Spirit on the church through the risen Jesus. All Israel was called upon to recognize that God had acted decisively to make the crucified Jesus both Lord and Messiah!

Acts 2:34–35

This passage quotes [Ps 110:1](#), which Jesus fulfilled when he ascended into heaven ([Acts 1:9](#)).

Acts 2:37–38

Brothers, what should we do? Peter answered by strongly exhorting his listeners to repent of your sins and turn to God, and be baptized. See “Baptism” Theme Note.

Acts 2:42

fellowship: Greek *koinōnia*, a close mutual relationship and participation in life together. • At this stage, prayer probably included participation in the formal prayers of the Temple (see [3:1](#)).

Acts 2:42–47

Luke makes a clear connection between personal faith and membership in the Christian community. Life in this new community involved devotion to the apostolic teaching of God’s Word, fellowship, sharing, joy, and praise, and it resulted in the Lord’s continuing to add to their number those who were being saved.

Acts 3:1–11

Jesus’ promise that his disciples would do even greater works than he had done ([John 14:12](#); see [Mark 16:20](#)) was fulfilled in the signs, wonders, and mighty works of the apostles ([Acts 2:43](#); [5:12](#); [8:4–8](#)). Here, Peter clearly exercised the power to heal in the name of Jesus Christ the Nazarene ([3:6](#), [16](#)). The cure was instant and undeniable ([3:8](#)), resulting in the man’s praising God ([3:8–9](#); cp. [2:47](#); [16:25](#); [Luke 2:20](#); [17:15–18](#); [18:43](#); [19:37](#); [24:53](#)). This is the first of many demonstrations of divine power given to disciples in Acts ([Acts 4:24–31](#); [5:12](#); [6:8](#); [8:6](#); [9:33–42](#); [28:8](#)).

Acts 3:6

The name of Jesus represents his identity and power to heal (see [Mark 9:38–39](#)).

Acts 3:10–11

The Beautiful Gate was probably the Nicanor Gate, built of Corinthian bronze and located on the east side of the Temple (see Josephus, *War* 5.5.3). It was adorned in a costly manner, with plates of silver and gold upon its panels richer and thicker than other gates. • Solomon’s Colonnade was a portico on the east side of the Temple (see Josephus, *War* 5.5.1–3; *Antiquities* 20.9.7).

Acts 3:12–26

The evangelistic speeches in the book of Acts focus on Jesus, the crucified and risen Lord. They call people to repentance and faith in Jesus as the promised Messiah and the divinely appointed Judge ([2:38](#); [3:19](#); [11:18](#); [17:30](#); [26:20](#)). They also offer the same Good News for the people of Israel and the Gentile world—“there is peace with God through Jesus Christ, who is Lord of all” ([10:36](#)).

Acts 3:15

It was unfathomable to the Jewish mind that the author of life, God himself, could be killed. They did not recognize Jesus as Messiah (cp. [13:27](#); [Luke 23:34](#)), and they did not realize that the Messiah would be divine (see [John 1:1–18](#); cp. [Dan 7:13–14](#)).

Acts 3:17

Friends: Literally *Brothers*, which was a common way to address one another ([13:15](#), [26](#), [38](#); [Gen 27:29](#); [Lev 10:6](#); [25:46](#); [Num 20:3](#); [Deut 1:28](#); [24:7](#); [Josh 22:3–4](#); [2 Sam 2:26](#); [Ezek 11:15](#)). • in ignorance: Cp. [Acts 17:30](#); [1 Tim 1:12–14](#). The Christian message challenges this ignorance and calls all people to respond in faith and repentance ([Acts 2:38](#)).

Acts 3:19

Other sections of the book of Acts and the Gospel of Luke explain the good news of “forgiveness” in more detail (see [Acts 5:30–32](#); [10:36–43](#); [13:26–38](#); [Luke 24:25–27](#), [45–47](#)).

Acts 3:19–21

The message of the good news about Jesus (the gospel) brings comfort (see [Matthew 11:28–29](#)). The second coming of Jesus will bring *times of refreshing* from God. He will *send Jesus* to his people again.

Acts 3:22

Jesus fulfills the ancient promise of a Prophet like Moses (see [Deut 18:15, 18](#); cp. [John 6:14; 7:40](#)).

Acts 3:23

Refusing to heed Jesus, God's final Prophet, would have disastrous consequences ([John 3:16, 17, 36](#)).

Acts 3:25

all the families on earth will be blessed: God's blessings on the covenant people were not intended to be selfishly hoarded, but were to be shared with the world.

Acts 4:1

Sadducees: See "The Sadducees" Profile.

Acts 4:1–22

Persecution was a common experience of God's people throughout the Bible. God's servants often faced hostility and opposition ([Deut 30:7](#); [1 Kgs 18:13](#); [Neh 4:1–3](#); [Jer 37–38](#); [Matt 23:34–37](#); [Luke 11:49–51](#); [1 Thes 2:14–15](#)). Jesus himself was persecuted ([Luke 4:29](#); [John 5:16](#)), and he told his disciples to expect the same kind of treatment ([Matt 10:23](#); [24:9](#); [Mark 13:9](#); [Luke 21:12](#); [John 16:2](#)), but he promised that the Holy Spirit would provide strength ([Acts 1:8](#); [Luke 12:11–12](#); [21:15](#)). Acts records frequent times of persecution ([Acts 4:3](#); [5:17–41](#); [7:54–8:3](#); [9:1–2](#); [11:19](#); [12:2](#); [13:50](#); [14:19](#); [16:19–24](#)), but Acts also reiterates that the Holy Spirit empowers disciples to bear witness in such circumstances ([2:44](#); [4:8–13](#); [6:10](#); [7:55](#)). The boldness of Peter and John before the hostile high council exemplifies facing persecution with courage and power ([4:20](#)).

Acts 4:4

the number of men who believed now totaled about 5,000: See study note on Matt 14:21.

Acts 4:13

ordinary men with no special training in the Scriptures: That is, they were not scholars or ordained teachers—they were working men without higher education. The educated members of the Jewish high council were treated as authorities on the Scriptures and matters of religion, so it amazed them to see uneducated men speaking with such boldness about such matters.

Acts 4:16–18

They recognized the miracle but still stubbornly tried to prevent the message. Jesus had encountered similar resistance ([Matt 19:8](#); [Mark 10:5](#); see also [Deut 10:16](#); [30:6](#); [Jer 4:4](#)).

Acts 4:19–20

The apostles stated a principle that can guide God's people in dealing with hostile authorities (see also [5:40](#); cp. [1 Sam 15:22](#); [Jer 7:23](#); [Luke 20:20–26](#); [Rom 13:1–7](#)). Jesus had predicted that his disciples would encounter hostility and persecution ([Luke 21:12–19](#)).

Acts 4:23–31

The believers heard the report that their leaders had been threatened and commanded never again to speak about Jesus ([4:18](#)). The Christian movement was clearly under attack from the religious authorities, so they united in prayer. They turned to God, placing their troubles before him and asking him to make them bold in speaking the message and to divinely confirm its truth with signs and wonders. God dramatically answered their request.

Acts 4:25-26

This passage quotes [Ps 2:1-2](#), which describes the response of the Gentile nations to the Lord's anointed king. In a similar manner, the Jews and Gentiles in Jerusalem had gathered together against Jesus and now against his followers.

Acts 4:26

The Hebrew term Messiah ("anointed one") originally referred to Israel's anointed king; it came to refer to the Messiah, the coming King of Israel who would establish God's Kingdom forever ([2 Sam 7:14-16](#); [Ps 89:36-37](#); [Isa 9:6-7](#); [11:1-9](#); [61:1](#); [Jer 23:5-6](#); [33:14-16](#); [Luke 1:32-33](#)).

Acts 4:28

God's hand had been directing events all along in order to achieve his purpose. A similar awareness of God's hand guiding the affairs of his people is found in the Old Testament (cp. [Ezra 7:6](#), [9](#), [28](#); [8:18](#), [31](#); [Neh 2:8](#), [18](#); [Eccl 9:1](#); [Ezek 8:1](#); [Rom 8:28](#); [1 Pet 5:6](#)).

Acts 4:32-35

The sharing of early believers was remarkable (see also [2:44-45](#); cp. [6:1](#)). Being united in heart and mind, they willingly offered anything they possessed to meet the needs of other believers. This sharing was voluntary and without coercion, and it related to pressing needs in the community and was prompted by Christian love and concern for one another.

Acts 4:36-37

Barnabas is held up as an example of generous, unselfish giving in response to the genuine needs in the Christian community.

Acts 5:1-11

Luke is fond of balancing a positive example with a negative example. He has just recorded the remarkable story of Barnabas ([4:36-37](#)). Now Luke presents the opposite conduct of Ananias and

Sapphira, who were tempted by the desire to be held in high regard. Ananias had not been forced to sell his property or to give the proceeds away. The couple's sin was in their pretense and deception.

Acts 5:3-4

In lying about their property sale, Ananias was not just lying to others but to the Holy Spirit—that is, to God. His actions compromised the transparent sincerity, unity, and integrity of the church at its very foundation, and thus he fell under the direct judgment of God (cp. [Lev 10:1-5](#); [Josh 7:16-26](#)).

Acts 5:11

Great fear gripped the entire church and everyone else who heard what had happened: The sudden judgment on Ananias and then on Sapphira had a sobering effect on both the Christian community and those who heard about this incident (cp. [Heb 10:31](#)). Believers were forcefully reminded that they needed to be pure, and for non-Christians the believers' integrity was reestablished, so that once again "all the people had high regard for them" ([Acts 5:13](#)). Yet it also made outsiders wary of joining a movement with such high standards ([5:13](#)). This divine "pruning" (see [John 15:1-11](#)) helped new growth to follow ([Acts 5:14](#); cp. [6:5-7](#); [11:24](#); [21:20](#)).

Acts 5:12-16

As in Jesus' ministry, the apostles' preaching was accompanied by many miraculous signs and wonders, including convincing works of healing and exorcism (see also [6:8](#); cp. [Matt 4:24](#); [9:35](#); [Mark 1:32-34](#); [Luke 4:40-41](#)).

Acts 5:13

no one else dared to join them: Perhaps the high standards of belief or what had happened to Ananias and Sapphira ([5:11](#)) were daunting to the crowds. • though all the people had high regard for them: Christians were markedly different from the unbelievers around them.

Acts 5:17-40

The success of the apostles' ministry again aroused strong opposition (cp. [4:1-3](#)). The wealthy and powerful Sadducees controlled the Temple establishment and had a Temple police force at their disposal. They opposed belief in the resurrection and were determined not to allow the apostles to proclaim their message about the resurrection of Jesus unchallenged. They also sensed that their hold on the Jewish people was loosening, so, filled with jealousy, they attacked the apostles.

Acts 5:19-20

The irony here is that the Sadducees denied the existence of angels ([23:8](#)). Angels frequently intervened in Acts (see also [10:3](#), [7](#), [22](#); [11:13](#); [12:6-11](#), [23](#); [27:23-24](#)). Luke presents God as guiding his people in their ministry, using angels to accomplish his purpose.

Acts 5:29

See study note on 4:19-20.

Acts 5:30-32

We are witnesses of these things: The apostles, as witnesses, were required to testify to what they had seen and heard (see [Lev 5:1](#); cp. [Acts 1:8](#); [Matt 28:18-20](#); [Luke 24:44-49](#); [John 20:21](#)).

Acts 5:33-40

God once again thwarted the Jewish leaders' plans to stop the apostles—this time through the counsel of Gamaliel.

Acts 5:34

Gamaliel was an eminent Pharisee, a leader in the Jewish high council, and a famous teacher of the law. He was Paul's teacher during his rabbinical education (see [22:3](#)).

Acts 5:36-37

This Theudas is otherwise unknown, although Josephus mentions a different man by that name who raised a revolt some years later (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.5.1). Theudas was a common Jewish name. • Judas of Galilee appears in Josephus as a rebel who opposed giving tribute to Caesar about AD 6 or 7, following the census of Quirinius (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.5.2; cp. [Luke 2:2](#)). His resistance, too, was crushed.

Acts 6:1

The Greek-speaking believers were Jewish Christians who had lived elsewhere in the Greco-Roman world and probably observed some Greek customs. The Hebrew-speaking believers were more traditional Jews, native to Palestine, who spoke Hebrew or Aramaic and refrained from Greek customs. • their widows were being discriminated against: This injustice threatened the growth and development of the church with rumblings of discontent and had to be addressed.

Acts 6:2-6

Wisely, the apostles called a meeting of all the believers to address the dispute. They recognized the seriousness of the problem, as well as their own priority of teaching the word of God. The solution was to select wise and Spirit-filled men to oversee the food distribution. The community accepted the apostles' solution and chose good leaders from the ranks of the Greek-speaking believers (all of their names are Greek). These seven devoted themselves to this special ministry, allowing the apostles to spend their time in prayer and teaching the word. • These seven men are sometimes called the first deacons because of the similarity of their role to the office of deacon (see [1 Tim 3:8-13](#)). Although the Greek term translated "deacon" (Greek diakonos, "servant") is not used here, a related Greek word is translated running a food program ([6:2](#); Greek diakonein, "to serve").

Acts 6:7

The result of the apostles' wise handling of the issue was growth and increase in the number of believers, including many of the Jewish priests. •

This is the first of three places in Acts where Luke notes that God's message continued to spread (see also [12:24](#); [19:20](#)). When real difficulties arose, God's message could overcome the challenges posed by internal strife, idolatry, and paganism, and the result was growth in the community. Acts is the story of the unhindered message of Good News (see [28:31](#)).

Acts 6:8–15

The Jewish leaders did to Stephen as they had done to Jesus (cp. [Matt 26:3–4](#), [59–66](#)): They got someone to lie about him, accused him of blasphemy, incited a riot, arrested him, and posted false charges against him.

Acts 6:15

His face became as bright as an angel's, just as Moses' face had ([6:14](#); see [Exod 34:32–35](#)). Stephen, like Moses, was bringing God's instruction to Israel (see also [2 Cor 3:7–18](#)).

Acts 7:1–53

Stephen responded to the accusations by testifying about his Lord (cp. [Luke 21:12–17](#)). Instead of defending himself against their prosecution, he became a witness in God's prosecution of them, exposing their stubbornness and unfaithfulness to God. Stephen's recital of Israel's past reminded them of their repeated rejections of those whom God had sent. • Stephen's review of Israel's history has three principal parts, dealing with the work of the patriarchs ([Acts 7:2–16](#)), the ministry of Moses ([7:17–43](#)), and the role of the Tabernacle and the Temple ([7:44–50](#)). Stephen followed up his historical survey with a clear attack on the hard-heartedness of his own people. With a prophetic challenge, he urged them to stop rebelling against the Holy Spirit and turn to God with repentance and faith.

Acts 7:8

the covenant of circumcision: See [Gen 17:9–14](#); see also "Circumcision in the New Testament" Theme Note.

Acts 7:14

Compare this figure with the *seventy* mentioned in the Hebrew text of [Gen 46:27](#). The number seventy-five is probably taken from the Septuagint (the Greek translation of the Old Testament) for [Gen 46:27](#). The Septuagint includes three descendants of Ephraim and two of Manasseh at [Gen 46:20](#), making for a total of five more persons, whereas the Hebrew text does not include descendants for Joseph's sons. The New Testament authors often quote from the Septuagint, which sometimes differs from the Hebrew Masoretic Text.

Acts 7:16

a certain price: Four hundred pieces of silver, according to [Gen 23:16](#).

Acts 7:37

This verse quotes [Deut 18:15](#). Moses had prophesied that the Messiah would come, and it had happened as Moses said.

Acts 7:39–40

Just as the ancient Jews had rejected what Moses was saying, now Stephen was speaking to descendants who were still rejecting God's deliverers—in this case, Jesus, the ultimate deliverer.

Acts 7:42–43

This passage quotes [Amos 5:25–27](#) (Greek version) to illustrate how the people of Israel rebelled against Moses ([Acts 7:39–41](#)). Molech was a Canaanite god to whom human sacrifices were offered ([Lev 18:21](#); [20:2–5](#); [1 Kgs 11:7](#); [2 Kgs 23:10](#); [Jer 32:35](#)). Rephan, a star god identified with the planet Saturn, was worshiped by the Israelites during their wilderness wanderings.

Acts 7:48–50

One of the charges was that Stephen was speaking against the Temple (cp. [6:14](#)). The leading priests and scribes controlled the Temple commerce and had a vital business interest in maintaining their enterprises unhindered (see [Luke 19:45–48](#)). That is why these leaders were so worried about the Temple despite the fact that God himself had said that the Most High doesn't live in temples made by human hands.

Acts 7:51

Stephen raised the same charge that God had raised against his people in the wilderness: that they were heathen at heart and deaf to the truth, because they were rejecting the gospel and obstinately resisting the Holy Spirit (see [Exod 32:9](#); [33:3](#); [34:9](#); [Deut 9:6](#), [13](#); [31:27](#); see also [Ps 78:8](#); [Zech 7:11–12](#)).

Acts 7:55–56

Jesus standing . . . at God's right hand: Usually Jesus is described as *seated* in heaven at God's right hand ([2:33–34](#); [5:31](#); [Luke 20:42](#); [22:69](#); [Rom 8:34](#); [Eph 1:20](#); [Col 3:1](#); [Heb 1:3](#), [13](#); [10:12](#)). One possible explanation is that Jesus was welcoming Stephen, the first martyr, to heaven with honor. Stephen had confessed his Lord faithfully on earth, and now his Lord honored his promise to confess his faithful servant in heaven, standing as a witness to defend him ([Matt 10:32](#); [Luke 12:8](#)). • the Son of Man standing: Cp. [Dan 7:13–14](#). The Jewish leaders understood that Stephen was speaking of Jesus as the divine Son of Man ([Acts 7:57](#)), a title that speaks of Jesus' power and authority (cp. [Rev 1:12–15](#)).

Acts 7:57

they put their hands over their ears: They believed that the comparison of Jesus to the divine Son of Man ([7:56](#)) was horrible blasphemy.

Acts 7:58

Saul was the Hebrew form, Paul the Greek form of his name (see [13:9](#)).

Acts 7:59–60

Stephen's prayer, Lord, don't charge them with this sin, is strikingly similar to Jesus' prayer at his crucifixion ([Luke 23:34](#)). Jesus clearly taught his followers the importance of both forgiveness ([Matt 6:14–15](#); [Mark 11:25](#); see [Luke 11:4](#); [17:3–4](#)) and prayer ([Luke 11:5–10](#); [18:1–8](#); see also [Acts 1:12–15](#); [4:23–31](#); [12:5](#); [Jas 5:16–18](#)). The Lord answered Stephen's prayer affirmatively in the case of Saul ([Acts 9:1–43](#)).

Acts 8:1–4

Saul: Cp. [9:1–2](#); [22:4](#); [26:9–11](#); [Gal 1:13–14](#). The result of this great wave of persecution was that all the believers . . . were scattered. Rather than having their enthusiasm dampened, however, they simply spread the Good News about Jesus wherever they went.

Acts 8:7

cast out . . . healed: Miracles often accompany evangelism in Acts (see study note on [3:1–11](#)).

Acts 8:9–24

Simon the sorcerer was a showman, dazzling the people of Samaria and making self-exalting claims. Simon's attempt to obtain spiritual power through payment gave the name *simony* to the later corrupt practice of buying and selling ordination to church leadership (cp. [1 Tim 6:9–10](#)). Peter strongly rebuked Simon's wickedness.

Acts 8:14–17

When the apostles sent two of their own to Samaria, it was an amazing step in overcoming prejudice (cp. [Matt 10:5](#); [Luke 9:52–54](#); [John 4:9](#); [8:48](#)). Then, it was even more amazing that Peter and John prayed that the new Samaritan believers would receive the Holy Spirit. This event parallels the day of Pentecost in Jerusalem ([Acts 2:1–47](#)) and marks the spread of the Holy Spirit's power from Judea to Samaria ([1:8](#)).

Acts 8:24

Simon recognized the need for Peter to intercede in prayer for him, but it is not clear that he repented and turned from his wickedness. His main concern was apparently to avoid the terrible consequences that Peter predicted when his wicked motives were exposed.

Acts 8:26–40

Philip obeyed the Holy Spirit's leading and then seized the opportunity to share the message of Good News with a eunuch on the desert road . . . from Jerusalem to Gaza. This incident shows Philip's remarkable effectiveness as a Christian apologist and evangelist in his outreach for Christ and in his commitment to bringing the Good News to all people regardless of social class or ethnicity.

Acts 8:27

In the ancient world, a eunuch was an official, typically castrated, who served in a royal court (see [2 Kgs 9:30–32](#); [Esth 1:10](#); [2:3](#), [14–15](#), [21](#); [4:4–5](#)). Eunuchs were often scorned by Jews because they could not perpetuate the covenant family, and the law of Moses excluded men who had damaged genitals from the assembly of Israel ([Deut 23:1](#); cp. [Lev 21:17–23](#)), but Isaiah spoke of God's acceptance of Gentiles and eunuchs ([Isa 56:3–8](#); see also [Matt 19:12](#)). In the new covenant, all who have genuine faith have a place among the people of God. • The eunuch had traveled from Africa to Jerusalem to worship in the Temple, probably for one of the great Jewish festivals.

Acts 8:29

The Holy Spirit guides the servants of God in where, when, and what to preach, teach, or do ([9:15](#); [10:19–20](#); [11:12](#); [16:6](#); [1 Cor 2:13](#); [1 Pet 1:12](#)).

Acts 8:32–33

The passage of Scripture was [Isa 53:7–8](#), one of the Servant Songs of Isaiah, a passage that speaks of the suffering servant of the Lord.

Acts 8:39–40

After the Spirit of the Lord snatched Philip away, Philip continued northward from Azotus (=Ashdod, [1 Sam 5:1–7](#); [Neh 13:23–24](#); [Isa 20:1](#)) up the coast, preaching in every town along the way until he came to Caesarea, where he settled ([Acts 21:8](#)). • Caesarea Maritima, a major seaport on the Mediterranean, was the seat of Roman government in Judea. It was built by Herod the Great about 22–9 BC and was named to honor Caesar Augustus.

Acts 9:1–19

The conversion of Saul of Tarsus on the Damascus road is of central importance to the narrative of Acts—Luke recounts the story three times (also [22:1–21](#); [26:1–29](#)). Paul (Saul) also alludes to this experience several times in his letters ([1 Cor 15:8–10](#); [Gal 1:11–17](#); [Phil 3:4–11](#); see [1 Tim 1:12–17](#)). Saul's conversion was his prophetic call and commission as an apostle ([Acts 9:15](#); [22:15](#), [21](#); [26:15–18](#)). No one is beyond the power of God to reach, redeem, and use for holy purposes—nothing is impossible with God ([Luke 1:37](#)). Paul was prepared through his training, upbringing, and experience to play a unique role in taking the gospel into the broader world as the “apostle to the Gentiles” ([Rom 11:13](#); see [1 Cor 15:9](#); [2 Cor 12:11–12](#); [Gal 1:1](#); [Eph 3:8](#)).

Acts 9:2

The synagogues (Greek *sunagōgē*, “gathering place”) were local Jewish meeting places. After the Exile, Jews began to meet in local synagogues as places of instruction and centers of worship. Synagogue services consisted of the reading of the Law and the Prophets, exposition of the Scriptures, prayer, praise, and thanksgiving (see [13:15](#); [15:21](#); [Neh 9:5](#); [Matt 6:5](#); [Luke 4:16–21](#)). Jesus attended, taught, preached, and performed miracles in synagogues ([Matt 12:9–10](#); [Mark 1:21](#), [39](#); [Luke 4:16](#); [13:10–13](#); [John 6:59](#); [18:20](#)), as did the apostles (see [Acts 9:20](#); [13:5](#), [14](#); [14:1](#); [17:1](#), [10](#), [17](#); [18:4](#), [19](#), [26](#)). • Damascus, the capital of Syria, was an important center with a long and distinguished past and the nearest major city outside of Palestine. It took from four to six days to reach Damascus from Jerusalem, a fact that highlights Saul's earnestness ([9:1–5](#); see [22:4–8](#); [26:9–15](#)). • The expression the Way is used in Acts for Christianity (see [19:9](#), [23](#); [24:14](#), [22](#))—it is “the way of God”

([18:26](#)) that tells people “how to be saved” ([16:17](#), literally *the way of salvation*). See also [John 14:6](#); [2 Pet 2:2](#).

Acts 9:10

Ananias: See also [22:12](#). The name Ananias was quite common (note the husband of Sapphira, [5:1](#), and the Jewish high priest [AD 47–59], [23:2](#)). • a vision: See “Visions” Theme Note.

Acts 9:15

Saul is my chosen instrument to take my message to the Gentiles: In God’s plan for spreading the Good News, the Gentiles were the next step (see [1:8](#); cp. chs [10–11](#)). Saul of Tarsus (Paul) was God’s choice to spearhead this expansive missionary effort to bring the Christian message to the Gentiles and to kings, as well as to the people of Israel. The rest of Acts illustrates Saul’s (Paul’s) faithfulness in carrying out this divine commission (e.g., [26:19–23](#)).

Acts 9:16

As Jesus predicted, Paul suffered greatly for his faith (see [2 Cor 11:23–27](#); see [Acts 13:45](#); [14:19](#); [16:22–27](#); [21:30–31](#); [26:21](#); [2 Tim 1:11–12](#)).

Acts 9:17

Ananias’s God-given role was to welcome Saul into the Christian family, beginning with laying hands on Saul to heal him and fill him with the Holy Spirit.

Acts 9:20–21

immediately he began preaching about Jesus: The genuineness of Saul’s encounter with the risen Christ is attested by the enthusiasm and boldness of his preaching. Saul’s outspoken declaration provoked astonishment, for he was the very man who had created such devastation among Jesus’ followers in Jerusalem.

Acts 9:22–25

Despite the bewilderment of his hearers, Saul so compellingly presented the evidence for the claims of Jesus as Messiah that the non-believing Jews in Damascus found themselves unable to refute it. Apparently this went on for some time (see [Gal 1:18](#)), so some of the non-believing Jews launched a plot on his life, but he was spared when some believers let him down out of the city in a large basket. Paul recounts this incident in [2 Cor 11:32–33](#).

Acts 9:26–28

When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, the Christian community understandably did not immediately trust him, given his recent history of violently persecuting Christians ([8:3](#); [9:1](#), [13](#); [22:3](#), [4](#); [26:9–11](#)). Fortunately, Barnabas, the “Son of Encouragement” ([4:36](#)), introduced the changed man to the apostles and explained his encounter with the Lord at Damascus, his sense of calling, and his subsequent boldness in preaching in the name of Jesus in Damascus. Barnabas was able to convince the apostles that Saul’s conversion was genuine, so Saul remained with the apostles in Jerusalem, where he preached boldly for his Lord. Paul recalls this visit in [Gal 1:18–19](#).

Acts 9:29

Again Saul debated with some Greek-speaking Jews, and again an assassination was planned (cp. [9:22–24](#)).

Acts 9:30

After the believers heard about the plot, Saul was once again sent away (cp. [9:25](#)), this time to Tarsus, his hometown, the capital of Cilicia (see [21:39](#); [22:3](#); [23:34](#); cp. [Gal 1:21](#)).

Acts 9:31

This verse is one of several in Acts that detail the numerical and spiritual growth of the church (see also [2:41](#); [4:4](#); [5:14](#); [6:1](#), [7](#); [12:24](#); [21:20](#)). • The first Christians were discovering the truth of the principle, “the fear of the Lord is the foundation of

true knowledge” ([Prov 1:7](#); [9:10](#); cp. [Job 28:28](#); [Ps 111:10](#); [Eccl 12:13](#); see [Luke 7:16](#)), and they were growing in their faith (cp. [Acts 2:43](#); [19:17](#)).

Acts 9:32-43

These verses describe Peter’s itinerant ministry in Judea, particularly along the seacoast. Exercising spiritual powers given to him by God, Peter performed wonderful works, including the healing of Aeneas and the raising of Dorcas. Jesus had promised such signs and wonders to the disciples ([John 14:12](#)). • Typical of Luke’s writing, the healing of a man is matched by the healing of a woman (see [Luke 13:10-17](#); [14:1-6](#)). The people in the area were deeply moved by these miracles, and many were drawn into the faith ([Acts 9:35](#), [42](#)).

Acts 9:43

living with Simon, a tanner of hides: Tanning was an unclean business in Jewish eyes, which might suggest that Peter was not scrupulous in observing Jewish traditions (cp. [Gal 2:11-14](#)).

Acts 10:1-8

a Roman army officer: Literally *a centurion*, the highest-ranking non-commissioned officer in the Roman army, in command of a *century*, a subdivision of roughly 100 men. Luke often describes centurions in favorable terms ([10:22](#); [21:32](#); [22:25-26](#); [23:17](#), [23](#); [27:6](#), [11](#), [43](#); [28:16](#); [Luke 7:1-10](#); [23:47](#)). It was important for Luke to show that Christianity was not hostile to Roman officials or institutions and could, like Judaism, be permitted in the Roman Empire (see Acts Book Introduction, “Purposes of Acts: Politics”). • a captain of the Italian Regiment: A regiment included six centuries; a Roman legion was usually divided into ten regiments. The New Testament mentions the Italian Regiment and the Imperial Regiment ([Acts 27:1](#)).

Acts 10:2

a devout, God-fearing man: Gentiles who are described as *God-fearing* were attracted to the high ethical standards of Judaism but were not prepared to accept the rite of circumcision or the full

implications of the Jewish law by becoming full converts to Judaism (cp. [13:43](#)). Christianity was an attractive option to Gentiles who worshiped God ([18:7](#); see [13:48](#); [16:30](#); [17:4](#), [12](#), [17](#)). These people would be wide open to the message of the gospel that announced that “there is peace with God through Jesus Christ” ([10:36](#)).

Acts 10:3

In Acts, visions are usually related to prayer ([9:3-6](#), [10-16](#); [10:2-6](#), [9-12](#); [11:5-9](#); [12:9-17](#); [18:9-10](#); [22:17-21](#); [23:11](#)). These visions are not chance coincidences, but expressions of God’s saving work, providing divine direction and encouragement.

Acts 10:9-16

Peter received the same vision three times to confirm its truthfulness (see [Gen 41:32](#); [2 Cor 13:1](#)).

Acts 10:14

See [Lev 11](#) for a description of animals that Jewish laws have declared impure and unclean.

Acts 10:17

Peter was very perplexed: The meaning of the vision would become clear through the events that followed ([10:17-48](#); see [11:1-18](#)): Peter should not hesitate to enter or even eat in the home of a Gentile because God has accepted Gentiles and cleansed them.

Acts 10:25-26

Cornelius . . . worshiped him: This act must have been more than traditional obeisance to a high-ranking person. The Bible restricts worship to God alone (see [14:11-17](#); [Exod 20:3](#); [Deut 5:7](#); [Matt 22:37-38](#); [Mark 12:29-30](#); [Luke 10:27](#); [1 Cor 10:14](#); [Col 3:5](#); [1 Pet 4:3](#); [1 Jn 5:21](#); [Rev 4:10](#); [9:20](#); [22:8-9](#)). Peter was just a fellow human being whom Cornelius should not worship.

Acts 10:34–35

God shows no favoritism: See [Deut 10:17](#); [2 Chr 19:7](#); [Job 34:19](#); [Luke 20:21](#); [Rom 2:11](#); [Gal 2:6](#); [Col 3:25](#); [1 Pet 1:17](#). The application of this principle is the meaning of Peter's vision ([10:9–16](#)). • In every nation he accepts those who fear him and do what is right: See [Rom 10:11–13](#).

Acts 10:36–43

Peter repeatedly underscores the importance of the apostolic witnesses to the message of Good News. The apostles ate and drank with Jesus (see [Luke 24:41–43](#)) and were eyewitnesses of his resurrection, so they could attest that he had conquered death (see [Acts 3:15](#); [4:33](#); [13:30–31](#)). The original apostles were chosen in advance to be his witnesses (see [1:12–26](#)); gradually, others such as Paul and Barnabas carried on this powerful preaching and teaching in the name of Jesus Christ ([9:15](#); [14:1–3](#); [26:16](#)).

Acts 10:43

Based on what they had seen and heard ([10:39–42](#)), the apostles could proclaim that Jesus of Nazareth was indeed the one all the prophets testified about. The whole plan of the Scriptures is profoundly centered in Christ (see [Luke 24:25–27](#); [44–47](#); [John 5:39](#)). • The major point of their message was that everyone who believes in him will have their sins forgiven through his name (see [Luke 24:47](#)).

Acts 10:44–48

On the day of Pentecost, Peter told the assembly that if they would repent, turn to God, and be baptized in the name of Jesus for the forgiveness of sins, they would receive “the gift of the Holy Spirit” ([2:38](#); cp. [19:1–7](#)). As Cornelius and his household listened to Peter's message, the Holy Spirit fell upon them, too, and they were baptized. They received the Holy Spirit just as the Jews did, so clearly God had shown no partiality ([10:34–35](#)). This event parallels the day of Pentecost in Jerusalem ([2:1–47](#)) and marks the spread of the Holy Spirit's power to Gentiles ([1:8](#); [2:39](#)).

Acts 10:48

Cornelius asked Peter to stay with them for several days, perhaps because of his need for instruction in the Christian way.

Acts 11:1–18

Jews traditionally kept themselves separate and did not eat or associate socially with Gentiles ([10:28](#); [22:21–22](#); see [John 4:9](#), [27](#); [18:28](#); [Gal 2:12–14](#)). Therefore, when the Jewish believers in Jerusalem learned that Gentiles had received the word of God, they criticized Peter's unconventional actions and wanted an explanation, which Peter provided.

Acts 11:4–17

Peter reviewed the sequence of events, explaining that the whole development was the result of God's initiative ([11:12](#)). Peter had eaten with Gentiles because God had made it clear that he should ([11:4–12](#)). Peter had then observed the Holy Spirit's definite action of coming upon Gentiles, and he realized that they were being accepted and blessed by God just as Jewish believers had been ([11:15–17](#); see [1:5](#)). Peter was submitting to God's will in admitting Gentiles to the church.

Acts 11:18

Peter's logical, straightforward explanation convinced those who had objected—they recognized God's hand at work in the conversion of the Gentiles and their receiving eternal life. However, issues relating to the inclusion of Gentiles would soon provoke a major crisis ([15:1–35](#); Paul's letter to the Galatians).

Acts 11:19–26

The persecution that followed Stephen's death forced believers into other areas ([8:1–3](#)), and they traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch. • Antioch of Syria was a thriving cosmopolitan city, the third-largest in the Roman Empire after Rome and Alexandria. Antioch was of central importance in the spread of the Christian message to the Gentile world.

Acts 11:20

This outreach effort on the part of Jewish believers ... from Cyprus and Cyrene was the first systematic attempt to preach to Gentiles about the Lord Jesus.

Acts 11:21–24

Once again, as had happened in the household of Cornelius, Gentiles turned to the Lord in considerable numbers. The explosion of Christian faith into the Gentile world had to remain in harmony with the church at Jerusalem, so the Jerusalem church sent Barnabas to Antioch to oversee developments there. He could see that God's blessing was on what was happening, so he endorsed it with joy.

Acts 11:25–26

Barnabas recognized the special gifts that Saul possessed for preaching and teaching. His assessment of Saul's gifts was wise, and it resulted in a fruitful team ministry in Antioch.

Acts 11:26

Christians was possibly a term of derision. The Greek text uses this term in only two other New Testament passages ([26:28](#); [1 Pet 4:16](#)).

Acts 11:27–28

some prophets: See "The Gift of Prophecy" Theme Note. • Agabus: See also [21:10–12](#).

Acts 11:28

Claudius, nephew of Tiberius Caesar ([Luke 3:1](#)), was the Roman emperor in AD 41–54. His last wife was his niece Agrippina, whose son Nero he adopted.

Acts 11:29–30

The upshot of Agabus's prophecy was that the believers in Antioch decided to make a contribution to the Jewish believers—the brothers and sisters—in Judea. The believers in Antioch gave as generously as they could and committed the responsibility for this financial aid to leaders they trusted, namely, to Barnabas and his fellow worker Saul. This unified love and support of Christians for one another was a tangible demonstration of the difference Christ had made in their lives. Paul describes this visit in his letter to the Galatians ([Gal 2:1–10](#)).

Acts 11:30

This is the first reference in Acts to elders as officers of the Christian church (see also [14:23](#); [15:2–23](#); [16:4](#); [20:17–35](#); [21:18](#); cp. [1 Tim 3:1–7](#); [Titus 1:5–9](#)).

Acts 12:1–5

Jesus had clearly predicted persecution and hardship for his followers ([Luke 11:49–51](#)). For the first time since Jesus' death, Roman authorities took direct violent action against the church. James, the brother of John, was one of the first called to be a disciple ([Mark 1:16–20](#); [Luke 5:1–11](#)), and he was one of the first Christians to be martyred for his faith. • King Herod Agrippa attacked the church (cp. [Acts 12:20–23](#)), a move that he found to be politically helpful with the Jewish people. The letter of James, the brother of Jesus, was probably written after this persecution to the scattered Christians (see [8:1–4](#); James Book Introduction, "Date of Writing").

Acts 12:4

Herod had Peter guarded by four squads of soldiers, making it humanly impossible for the apostle to escape (cp. [12:6](#)). However, God was in charge, and nothing is too hard for him (cp. [4:27–31](#); [Gen 18:14](#); [Jer 32:17, 27](#); [Matt 19:26](#); [Mark 10:27](#); [Luke 1:37](#); [18:27](#)).

Acts 12:5

the church prayed very earnestly: God answers the earnest prayers of his people ([12:6-17](#); see [Luke 11:1-13](#); [18:1-8](#); cp. [Matt 7:7-11](#); [John 15:7](#); [Phil 4:6-7](#); [Jas 5:16](#); [1 Jn 3:22](#)).

Acts 12:6-19

God, through an angel, led Peter out, reunited him with his praying friends, and sent him out to carry on the work of spreading the Good News. The message advanced despite determined opposition.

Acts 12:7-11

See “Angels” Theme Note.

Acts 12:12

The home of Mary, the mother of John Mark, was evidently a gathering place for believers. John Mark later became a missionary colleague of Barnabas and Saul ([12:25](#)).

Acts 12:13-17

Rhoda was so surprised when Peter appeared that she left him standing at the closed door. Both she and the other believers were amazed by God’s answer to their prayers ([12:5](#)).

Acts 12:18-23

When Peter couldn’t be found after a careful search, Herod interrogated the guards and put them to death (cp. [16:27](#)). However, Herod met his own painful end as a divine judgment on his conceit when he accepted the people’s worship. Josephus records the death of Herod Agrippa I in greater detail (Josephus, *Antiquities* 19.8.1-2).

Acts 12:24-25

Herod’s demise from a terrible illness ([12:23](#)) contrasts with the growth of the Christian church and the unhindered message of Good News ([28:31](#)).

Acts 13:1

prophets and teachers: See “The Gift of Prophecy” Theme Note; see also [1 Cor 12:28-29](#); [Eph 4:11](#). • The name Simeon suggests a Jewish background (see [Gen 29:33](#); [Luke 2:25](#); [3:30](#)); he is also called “the black man”—he was probably of African descent. • Lucius is a Latin name; he came from Cyrene, the capital of Libya in North Africa. He was probably one of the preachers from Cyrene who had brought the Christian message to Antioch ([Acts 11:20](#)). • Manaen had been brought up with King Herod Antipas; he was probably Luke’s source for insight into Antipas’s thoughts and actions (see [Luke 9:7-9](#)). • Barnabas and Saul are prominently featured in the subsequent narrative.

Acts 13:1-3

The prophets and teachers of the church at Antioch spent significant time in worship and prayer, earnestly seeking the Lord’s will as they fasted and opened themselves to divine direction. As they prayed, the Holy Spirit spoke to them, and they set apart Barnabas and Saul in clear recognition of God’s call for them to carry out a special work in his name. The believers’ inward journey in prayer and listening to God is matched by their outward journey in service, evangelism, and mighty works of healing and salvation.

Acts 13:3

the men laid their hands on them: This solemn act was only done after more fasting and prayer; the Pastoral Epistles warn against laying hands on a person to appoint that person as a Christian leader without due care and diligence ([1 Tim 5:22](#)). At this point, Barnabas and Saul were sent . . . on their way as missionaries of the church at Antioch.

Acts 13:4

Barnabas and Saul’s first missionary journey was undertaken with a strong consciousness of the Holy Spirit as their guide. • Seleucia was Antioch’s ancient seaport, located about twelve miles (20 km) west of the city at the mouth of the Orontes River. • Their journey took them westward by sea

to the island of Cyprus, which was Barnabas's homeland ([4:36](#)).

Acts 13:5

Landing in the town of Salamis on the eastern end of Cyprus, they went to the Jewish synagogues (see study note on 9:2), where the Jews could hear and respond to the Christian message. They would also meet converts to Judaism (see study note on 13:43) and spiritually hungry Gentiles who are sometimes described as "God-fearers" (see study note on 10:2).

Acts 13:6

Paphos was located on the southwest coast of Cyprus. As the leading city of Cyprus, it was of strategic importance. • a Jewish sorcerer . . . named Bar-Jesus: Such eastern magicians often exercised a tremendous influence in the Greco-Roman world.

Acts 13:6–12

At Paphos there was a power struggle with a false prophet, with the result that the power of God was manifested and the Roman governor became a believer.

Acts 13:7–8

The governor, Sergius Paulus, who was an intelligent man, was attracted to the teaching of Barnabas and Saul. But Elymas (the sorcerer's Greco-Roman name) recognized a challenge to his power and strongly opposed the message of Barnabas and Saul.

Acts 13:9

Luke makes the significant transition from the name Saul (a Hebrew name) to Paul (a Greco-Roman name), perhaps indicating that Paul was now on a predominantly Gentile mission. For the rest of the book of Acts, he is called Paul except when he recounts his conversion (as in [22:7](#), [13:26:14](#)).

Acts 13:10–11

Paul, who became the chief spokesman, rebuked the sorcerer's fraudulent claims, exposed his deceit, and pronounced divine judgment (cp. [8:20–24](#)). The sorcerer was instantly struck blind, a condition that lasted for some time, giving a strong demonstration of the truthfulness and superiority of the apostolic message over the bogus claims of the sorcerer.

Acts 13:12

The teaching about the Lord included a miraculous demonstration of divine power (cp. [Mark 1:21–27](#)), for it was a teaching about the living God (see [Acts 14:15](#)).

Acts 13:13–14

They landed at the port of Perga. From here, major roads opened into the interior beyond the Taurus Mountains. • At this point, John Mark left the team for reasons that are not stated (see study note on 15:36–41). Possibly he was unhappy that the Good News was moving out into Gentile lands; possibly he was homesick or otherwise unable to continue a difficult journey. Whatever the reason, he returned to the more familiar and comfortable Jewish surroundings of Jerusalem.

Acts 13:14

Paul and Barnabas traveled inland into the high country and came to Antioch of Pisidia (in the Roman province of Galatia in Asia Minor, not to be confused with Antioch in Syria). As was their custom, the apostles began at the synagogue (see study note on 9:2; cp. [13:5](#); [14:1](#); [17:1](#), [2](#), [10](#), [17](#); [18:4](#), [19](#); [19:8](#)).

Acts 13:15

After the usual Scriptures for the day had been read, one from the books of Moses and the other from the prophets (see [Luke 4:16–28](#)), the officials of the synagogue invited the visitors to speak any word of encouragement for the people.

Acts 13:16–41

Paul accepted the invitation, motioned to quiet his audience (cp. [19:33](#); [21:40](#)), and launched into a straightforward proclamation of the Good News. This is Paul's first great speech in Acts, and it provides a model of his preaching to a Jewish audience (see [22:1–21](#)).

Acts 13:17–22

To establish common ground, Paul traced Jewish history from the Exodus onward, stressing the Jews' powerful deliverance from Egyptian bondage, the providential occupation of their inheritance in Canaan, the establishment of the monarchy, the removal of Saul, and the special place of David.

Acts 13:22

David was a man after God's own heart despite his sins (e.g., [2 Sam 11–12](#)).

Acts 13:23–25

Paul here moved to the theme of his message: Jesus, one of David's descendants, was God's promised Savior of Israel. The Messiah's way had been prepared by John the Baptist, who insisted that Israel needed to repent . . . and turn to God and be baptized. John was a humble servant who simply cleared the ground for the one whose coming he announced.

Acts 13:26–37

Paul reviewed the shameful treatment Jesus had received, involving unjust condemnation and death. But God raised Jesus from the dead, as attested by witnesses. This message provides good news, for through Jesus sinners can experience the forgiveness of sins. But this message must be met with faith, or dire consequences will follow.

Acts 13:31

The fact that Jesus was raised from the dead was well documented by witnesses.

Acts 13:38–41

Paul appealed for them to believe the message about Jesus, through whom there is forgiveness for your sins.

Acts 13:39

Faith is prerequisite to being made right in God's sight; this was not provided for in the law of Moses ([Ps 14:1–3](#); see [Rom 3:9–20](#)).

Acts 13:40–41

Paul closed his message with a strong warning (cp. [Heb 2:3](#)). The Good News must not be ignored, neglected, or rejected, or frightening consequences will follow.

Acts 13:42–43

The message stirred up interest among the people, and many of them were converted.

Acts 13:43

Full converts to Judaism (also called *proselytes*) were Gentiles who had gone through the rite of circumcision to become full members of the Jewish community, observing the Jewish law (see also [2:11](#); [6:5](#); [Matt 23:15](#)). • The grace of God is a key concept in the New Testament to describe God's unmerited favor shown preeminently through Jesus Christ.

Acts 13:44–49

The excitement caused by the apostles' preaching led to a mass turnout on the following week. This response provoked the jealousy of some of the Jews (cp. [4:1–2](#); [5:17](#)), whose ability to win converts to Judaism ([13:43](#)) was being dwarfed by Paul's ministry. They verbally attacked Paul and his ministry (cp. [6:8–12](#); [18:6](#); [19:9](#); [Matt 23:13](#)). Paul met this hostility with a bold declaration that these Jews had had their opportunity to hear the word of God, and that since they had rejected it, the offer of

salvation would now be given to the Gentiles (cp. [Acts 10:34–35](#)), in accord with the Lord's command in Scripture. The local Gentiles welcomed the Good News and many responded to it, so the Lord's message was carried throughout that region.

Acts 13:50–51

Jewish opposition once again forced Paul and Barnabas . . . out of town. They shook the dust from their feet as a sign of rejection, as Jesus had taught his disciples (see [Matt 10:14–15](#); [Mark 6:11–12](#); [Luke 9:5–6](#); [10:10–11](#)). That place was then treated as pagan territory, and other people were given access to the message of new life in Christ.

Acts 13:52

Despite probable harassment and persecution, the believers were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit (cp. [5:41](#); [16:23–25](#); [Matt 5:10–12](#); [2 Cor 8:2](#); [1 Thes 1:6](#)).

Acts 14:1

The missionaries moved on to the next town, Iconium (now called Konya), located east of Pisidian Antioch on a high plateau in south central Asia Minor. Iconium enjoyed a favorable location on several key trade routes. • In their usual fashion, Paul and Barnabas began their ministry in the area by speaking powerfully in the Jewish synagogue, which led to a great response from both Jews and Greeks.

Acts 14:2

Once again Paul and Barnabas faced hostile Jews who rejected the Christian message and also poisoned the minds of the Gentiles.

Acts 14:3

The Spirit-inspired apostles were resilient to withstand the verbal attack against them, and they persisted in preaching the Good News that God's grace was available to Gentiles as well as to Jews. • boldly: Spirit-inspired boldness is evident

throughout Acts (see [2:14](#); [4:9–10](#), [13](#); [7:2–53](#); [8:30–35](#); [9:27–28](#); [18:26](#); [19:8](#); [22:3–21](#); [23:1–6](#); [28:16–20](#), [23–31](#)). • In addition, the Holy Spirit confirmed the Christian message with miraculous signs and wonders (cp. [5:12–16](#); [15:12](#); [16:18](#); [19:11](#)).

Acts 14:4

The apostolic message required a decision about belief in Jesus, and opinion was clearly split. • Paul and Barnabas are called apostles for the first time (also in [14:14](#)), extending the idea of apostleship beyond the Twelve. Their message was in continuity with that of the original apostles, and they were prepared to suffer hardship and persecution for it as the earlier apostles had done ([5:41](#); [14:19](#); [20:24](#); [21:13–14](#); see also [Rom 8:35–38](#); [2 Cor 4:8–17](#)).

Acts 14:6

Lycaonia was a southern region of the Roman province of Galatia. Its major cities were Lystra, Derbe, Laranda, and Iconium. Acts reports two more visits by Paul to Lycaonia ([16:1–5](#); [18:23](#)). Paul's letter to the Galatians was probably addressed to scattered believers in the churches of Lycaonia (see Galatians Book Introduction, "Recipients"). • Lystra was located roughly twenty-five miles (40 km) south-southwest of Iconium. • Derbe, situated about thirty miles (50 km) southeast of Lystra, was on the busy major road that stretched from Iconium and Lystra eastward to Tarsus, the capital of Cilicia.

Acts 14:8–20

Paul's healing of a man with crippled feet recalls a similar incident in [3:1–12](#). In Acts, the work of Paul parallels the work of Peter, and the many miraculous signs and wonders performed among the Jews were also performed among the Gentiles.

Acts 14:9

Paul realized he had faith to be healed: Paul, full of the Holy Spirit ([9:17](#)), sensed the man's spiritual openness and expectancy for divine help and intervention.

Acts 14:11–13

Zeus was the patron god of Lystra, and the city had a temple in his honor. They associated Barnabas with Zeus, perhaps because he was the more impressive figure, and Hermes was identified with Paul . . . since he was the chief speaker. The native people of Lystra thought that they were being treated to a divine visitation similar to a past mythological appearance cited by the poet Ovid (in which the gods Zeus and Hermes came to visit the area but were unrecognized except by an old couple; see Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 8.616–724). So the people set out to honor these supposed gods.

Acts 14:13–18

The apostles opposed the people's idolatry and their attempt to offer sacrifices to them. They directed the people's worship to the living God; the apostles were his representatives as they brought the Good News of the Christian message.

Acts 14:19–20

The crowd became fickle when some Jews arrived from Antioch and Iconium and easily turned the people against the apostles. • They stoned Paul and dragged him out of town: Paul later referred to this time of persecution as a lesson ([2 Tim 3:11–12](#)). • thinking he was dead: That Paul got up and went back into the town suggests that God miraculously healed him of his wounds.

Acts 14:20

The next day he left: Paul later returned to Lystra on his second missionary journey ([16:1](#)).

Acts 14:22–23

The apostles were diligent in following up with those who had made a Christian profession of faith. These new disciples needed to be nurtured, supported, and encouraged ([15:32](#), [41](#); [16:40](#); [18:23](#); see [1 Thes 3:2](#); [4:18](#); [5:14](#)). • Paul and Barnabas ... appointed elders: See “Church Leaders” Theme Note.

Acts 14:26–28

As soon as Paul and Barnabas returned home to Antioch from their first missionary journey, they called the church together and gave a full report of their evangelism and discipleship. They humbly acknowledged divine guidance in opening the door of faith to the Gentiles (see [11:18](#); [1 Cor 16:9](#); [2 Cor 2:12](#)). Similar reports ([Acts 15:4](#), [12](#); [21:19](#)) always stressed the activity of God as working through the ministries of his servants (see [Rom 15:17–18](#); [1 Cor 3:5–9](#); [15:10–11](#)).

Acts 15:1

These men from Judea were Jewish Christians who taught the necessity of circumcision (and with it, conversion to Judaism) in order to be saved. The central issue was how Gentiles were to be received into Christian fellowship. Paul wrote his letter to the Galatians about this time to counter the same teaching in Galatia (see Galatians Book Introduction, “Date of Writing”).

Acts 15:2–3

The Antioch church decided to send . . . delegates to Jerusalem to resolve this matter in discussion with the apostles and elders there. En route, the entourage visited believers in Phoenicia and Samaria, where the Christian faith had made substantial inroads (ch [8](#)).

Acts 15:4–21

The first council of the church met to resolve the dispute concerning Gentiles and circumcision ([15:1–2](#)).

Acts 15:5

These Pharisees were believers, yet they retained their strong adherence to the law of Moses. Paul argued against their message most strenuously (see [Gal 1:6–9](#); [2:14–3:14](#)).

Acts 15:7–11

Peter, no doubt remembering his own experience in the household of Cornelius (ch [10](#)), argued that God had already confirmed his acceptance of the Gentiles without circumcision by giving them the Holy Spirit. The undeserved grace of the Lord Jesus had been made available to all.

Acts 15:13–19

James, the brother of Jesus, declared that the conversion of the Gentiles was clearly in accord with Scripture. He argued forcefully that it was contrary to the divine will to put unnecessary requirements on the admission of the Gentiles.

Acts 15:14

Peter: Greek *Simeon*. Peter's given name was Simon (see [Matt 16:17–19](#)).

Acts 15:15–19

Because God's prophets had predicted the conversion and inclusion of the Gentiles, James argued that the Gentiles should be accepted as Gentiles, without requiring them to practice Judaism ([15:1](#)).

Acts 15:20

Eating food offered to idols is sinful if it involves knowingly partaking of an idolatrous sacrifice (see [Exod 20:4](#); [Deut 5:8](#); [1 Cor 8:4–13](#); [10:14–30](#); [Rev 2:14, 20](#)). • Sexual immorality was common in the Greek world but is always sinful ([Exod 20:14](#); [Deut 5:18](#); [Gal 5:19](#)). • eating the meat of strangled animals: God's law prohibits eating meat that has blood in it ([Lev 17:13–14](#)) or consuming blood ([Lev 17:10–12](#)), “for the life of every creature is in its blood” ([Lev 17:14](#)). Also, “It is the blood, given in exchange for a life, that makes purification possible” (see [Lev 17:11](#) and study note). This command was first given to Noah, the ancestor of Gentiles as well as Jews ([Gen 9:4](#)).

Acts 15:22–29

The Jerusalem church chose two of the church leaders to report its decision. They took with them a letter from the apostles and elders . . . in Jerusalem explaining the terms of the agreement.

Acts 15:29

Farewell: The letter to the churches includes this familiar Hellenistic greeting at the end of a letter, found only here in the New Testament. Paul often ended his letters on a more theological note (e.g., [1 Cor 16:23–24](#); [2 Cor 13:13](#); see [Eph 6:23–24](#); [Phil 4:23](#); [Col 4:18](#); [1 Thes 5:23–28](#); [1 Tim 6:21](#)).

Acts 15:30–31

The believers at Antioch received the decision with great joy that conversion to Judaism and keeping all the requirements of the law of Moses was not required of them. The dispute had been resolved, so the work of teaching and preaching in Antioch could continue unimpeded.

Acts 15:36–41

The discordant separation of Paul and Barnabas is indicated by a very strong word in Greek (their disagreement was so sharp). It was an honest disagreement between two godly men about whether John Mark (Barnabas's cousin, [Col 4:10](#)) should be given a second chance to accompany them on a mission journey after he had deserted them in Pamphylia (see [Acts 13:13](#)). The rift between Paul and John Mark was eventually healed ([2 Tim 4:11](#)).

Acts 15:40–41

Following his disagreement with Barnabas over John Mark, Paul chose Silas as his partner for a second missionary journey through Syria and Cilicia. The two men traveled overland to visit Derbe and Lystra, explaining the decision of the Jerusalem council and strengthening believers in their faith.

Acts 16:1-3

Paul returned to churches that he and Barnabas had established on their previous journey.

Acts 16:3

Paul had Timothy circumcised to enhance Timothy's acceptance and effectiveness as a Jew in Jewish circles (contrast Titus, who was a full Gentile, [Gal 2:3](#)). Elsewhere Paul clarified that it makes no difference to God whether one is circumcised or not circumcised ([Rom 2:25-29](#); [Gal 5:6](#); [6:15](#)). Paul was prepared to use any legitimate means to communicate the Good News ([1 Cor 9:20-21](#)) to various audiences.

Acts 16:4-5

Paul and Silas faithfully communicated the decisions of the Jerusalem council. The wisdom of the decision was indicated as the churches were strengthened in their faith and grew larger every day (cp. [2:41](#); [4:4](#); [5:14](#); [6:1](#); [9:31](#); [21:20](#)).

Acts 16:6-10

God directed the missionaries' travels: The Holy Spirit had prevented them from proceeding westward into the province of Asia, the Spirit of Jesus did not allow them to go north to Bithynia, and then Paul had a vision calling them to go northwest over the Aegean Sea to Macedonia. God's Spirit guided his servants in Acts in a variety of ways, including divine visions (see also [9:10](#); [10:9-16](#); [22:18](#)), direct intuition (cp. [8:29](#), [39](#); [10:19](#); [20:22](#)), counsel with other believers (cp. [15:29](#)), guidance through prayer ([13:2](#), [4](#)), insight through Scripture ([28:25-27](#)), and prophecy ([11:28](#)). Guidance by the indwelling Holy Spirit helped them to accomplish their mission to be Christ's witnesses ([1:8](#); see also [4:8](#), [31](#); [11:24](#); [13:9](#)).

Acts 16:8

Troas, a major port on the Aegean Sea, was one of the more significant cities in the Roman Empire. Paul's strategy was often to visit principal places such as Troas, Athens, Corinth, and Ephesus. When the Christian faith had been planted in major

centers, local Christian workers could carry it into outlying areas (e.g., Epaphras took the message from Ephesus to Colosse, [Col 1:7](#); [4:12-13](#)).

Acts 16:9-10

a vision: See "Visions" Theme Note.

Acts 16:10

we: The most natural interpretation of the shift from "they" to "we" is that Luke accompanied Paul from Troas to Philippi ([16:10-17](#)). Later Luke joined Paul again at Philippi and sailed with him to Troas, then to Miletus ([20:5-15](#)), then from Miletus to Jerusalem ([21:1-18](#)). After Paul's two-year imprisonment in Caesarea, Luke traveled with him to Rome ([27:1-28:16](#)).

Acts 16:11

Samothrace is a small mountainous island lying west-northwest of the Hellespont about twenty miles (32 km) from the coast of Thrace. • Neapolis (modern Kavala) was the seaport for Philippi and the eastern terminus of the famous *Via Egnatia* (the Egnatian Way), which ran from Rome to Asia.

Acts 16:12

At Philippi, about ten miles (17 km) inland from Neapolis, Paul began his missionary labors in Europe.

Acts 16:13

The Jewish community at Philippi was too small to have a synagogue, which required ten adult males. Instead, Jews met for prayer in an open space by the Gangites (now called Angista) River that afforded privacy, quiet, and water for Jewish purification rites.

Acts 16:13-36

Luke gives his readers cameos of three lives touched by the Good News in Philippi: a wealthy

woman ([16:14-15](#)), an exploited slave girl ([16:16-21](#)), and a middle-class officer ([16:23-36](#)).

Acts 16:14-15

The first person changed by Christ in Philippi was Lydia, a successful businesswoman from Thyatira (modern Akhisar), a city of western Asia Minor famous for its woolen fabrics, weavers, and linens. Lydia responded to the message and she and her household were baptized (cp. [16:32-33](#)). • One of Lydia's first acts as a true believer in the Lord was to extend hospitality to the visiting missionaries. Hospitality is an important Christian virtue ([Matt 25:31-46](#); [Rom 12:13](#); [16:23](#); [1 Tim 3:2](#); [Titus 1:8](#); [Heb 13:2](#); [1 Pet 4:9](#); [3 Jn 1:5-8](#); cp. [Gen 18:1-8](#); [19:1-3](#); [24:23-33](#)).

Acts 16:16-18

The second portrait of a changed life in Philippi is of a slave girl who had a spirit that enabled her to tell the future. • Even though the demon within her was stating the truth, Paul, like Jesus, did not permit it to proclaim the Christian message (cp. [Mark 1:25](#), [34](#); [3:11-12](#); [Luke 4:35](#), [41](#)). The Lord had commanded that the gospel be proclaimed by his disciples, not by opponents ([Acts 1:8](#); [9:15](#); [26:15-18](#); [Matt 28:18-20](#); [Luke 24:46-49](#); [John 20:21](#); see [Acts 22:15](#)).

Acts 16:19-21

As in the ministry of Jesus, sometimes the Good News threatened established commercial interests (see also [19:25-27](#); [Mark 5:1-20](#)). The slave girl's exploiters viciously attacked the missionaries and dragged them before the authorities as criminals, blamed them for fomenting a disturbance, resorted to racial bias (these Jews), and appealed to the Philippians' pride (us Romans; the Philippians prided themselves on being Roman citizens of a Roman colony). • customs that are illegal: By law, Jews were not permitted to make converts of Romans.

Acts 16:22-24

All reasonable security measures were taken to ensure that Paul and Silas didn't escape after they

had been stripped and beaten with wooden rods (see [22:24-26](#); [2 Cor 6:5](#); [11:23-25](#)). As at Christ's tomb ([Matt 27:65](#)), however, human effort did not prevent divine intervention.

Acts 16:25

Paul and Silas, like the persecuted apostles in Jerusalem, were joyful, "rejoicing that God had counted them worthy to suffer disgrace for the name of Jesus" ([5:41](#)).

Acts 16:26

The massive earthquake is reminiscent of the great earthquake at Jesus' resurrection ([Matt 28:2-3](#)).

Acts 16:27

The Roman jailer clearly knew that his life could be forfeited if the prisoners for whom he was responsible escaped. This was standard practice ([12:19](#); [27:42](#); cp. *Code of Justinian* 9.4.4).

Acts 16:27-36

Luke's third portrait in Philippi is of the Philippian jailer who, shaken by what had happened, responded in faith when challenged to accept the Lord Jesus and be saved. He was baptized with his household and rejoiced in his newfound faith as he reached out with hospitality to the preachers.

Acts 16:29-30

Paul and Silas had impressed the jailer with their cheerful faith ([16:25](#)), their composure in crisis, and their concern for his well-being ([16:28](#)). Whatever the jailer's previous understanding of Paul's message, God touched his heart, and he cried out for divine help.

Acts 16:31-34

Paul and Silas directed the jailer to a faith in Christ that brings blessing both to him and to his family. The whole household received Christian

instruction, and their response was expressed in baptism and the offering of hospitality to Paul and Silas.

Acts 16:37–39

Paul and Silas were both Roman citizens, so the beating and imprisonment (16:22–24) had been illegal. After the city officials learned of this, they were justifiably alarmed because they had committed a crime against Rome. • Let them come themselves to release us: Paul made use of his rights as a Roman citizen in order to clear his name and ensure that no disrepute would attach to the Christian message or those who accepted it. Luke intended to show that Christianity should enjoy the same status as Judaism in the Roman Empire as a permitted religion—the Christian faith was compatible with the life of a Roman citizen. Accordingly, it was important to note that Paul made use of his rights as a Roman citizen (cp. 22:25–27) and was ready to use the privileges of citizenship to advance the cause of Christ in a hostile world.

Acts 16:40

This meeting in the home of Lydia bolstered the spirits of the Philippian Christians who had to deal with the fallout from the missionaries' work there.

Acts 17:1–3

Amphipolis was a Roman military post located on the Egnatian Way in the northeastern part of Macedonia. • Apollonia, named after the Greek god Apollo, was also situated on the Egnatian Way. • Thessalonica offered a starting point for ministry because it had a Jewish synagogue (see study note on 9:2). Paul was able to preach for three consecutive Sabbaths, explaining the Scriptures and showing their fulfillment in Jesus.

Acts 17:1–9

After traveling through Macedonia to Thessalonica, Paul preached to the Jews first (Rom 1:16) in the synagogue. Here, as elsewhere, there was a mixed response.

Acts 17:4

God-fearing Greek men: See study note on 10:2. • Luke regularly draws attention to women who joined the Christian movement (17:4, 12, 34; see also 5:14; 8:12; 16:13–15, 31–34; 18:26; 21:9).

Acts 17:5–7

Once again, the enemies of the Christian faith saw it as a disruptive threat (cp. 16:19–21). Ironically, they gathered some troublemakers and then accused Paul and Silas of causing trouble by disturbing the peace and committing treason against Caesar—serious charges of threatening the stability of the empire (cp. Luke 23:2).

Acts 17:8–9

The charges did not hold up under scrutiny, so the officials released Jason and the other believers after they posted bond. Christianity, Luke contended, was politically harmless to the Roman Empire and should therefore be recognized as a permitted religion and not subjected to political attack.

Acts 17:10–12

In light of the strong opposition in Thessalonica, the believers sent Paul and Silas to Berea, located about fifty miles (80.5 km) west of Thessalonica. There the missionaries had a better reception than in Thessalonica. Many Jews came to faith, as well as many of the prominent Greek women and men. The Bereans were exemplary in their attitude, for they were open-minded and eager to learn, good listeners, diligent Bible students, and thoughtful people. Their resulting faith had a strong foundation.

Acts 17:13–15

Paul acknowledged the determination and persistence of this persecution when he wrote to the Thessalonians (1 Thes 2:14–16).

Acts 17:16–17

Athens, like Alexandria and Tarsus, prided itself on its intellectual sophistication in examining ideas and considering the different philosophies that were current at the time.

Acts 17:16–34

In this chapter, we see Paul presented as a model witness for Christ, engaging the thinkers of his day and challenging them with the Christian message. Paul quoted writers his audience would be familiar with and showed the relevance of the gospel by dialoguing with them, critiquing their assumptions, and offering Jesus as a constructive alternative (see [Col 1:28](#)). Paul reminded these proud intellectuals that there is a living God to whom all human beings are answerable; that they will be judged by him through Jesus, whom God raised from the dead; and that they should therefore repent and put their faith in Jesus.

Acts 17:18

Epicurean . . . philosophers: Epicureanism was a popular school of Greek philosophy, founded by Epicurus (341–270 BC). Epicureans believed that the principal aim of life was to secure happiness. They thought of pleasure not in terms of sensual indulgence, as their critics charged, but in terms of tranquility. Their contemporaries often called them atheists; in their view, there were no gods to fear, and death simply marked the end of human existence. They sought their security in organized communities where they could live in contentment apart from society. • Stoic philosophers: Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium (335–263 BC) and became the most influential philosophy in the Greco-Roman world. It viewed the universe as permeated by Reason (sometimes referred to as God or Providence). Stoicism saw divine Reason as expressed in human reason and held that as humans made progress, they could advance from ignorance (the source of vice) to true knowledge (the source of virtue). They developed extensive lists of virtues and vices and produced detailed household codes to guide family behavior. Paul's teaching resembles that of the Stoics in his use of household codes and lists of virtues and vices ([Gal 5:19–23](#); [Eph 5:22–33](#); [Col 3:18–4:1](#); [1 Tim 3:1–13](#); [5:1–6:1](#)). However, Paul's message of Good News—focusing on the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus

Christ—was strange and foreign to these Greek philosophers. • The air of superiority with which they addressed Paul as this babblers indicates their arrogance.

Acts 17:22–31

Paul's remarkable sermon in Athens reveals his versatility in preaching the Good News ([Rom 11:14](#); [1 Cor 9:19–23](#); [10:33](#); cp. [Acts 16:3](#); [17:2–3](#); [21:20–26](#)). While Paul's Greek audience did not know the Scriptures or have a tradition of monotheism as the Jews did, they did have a rich intellectual heritage. So Paul established a point of contact on the basis of an Athenian inscription to an Unknown God. He then explained God's nature as the Creator ([17:22–29](#)), followed by God's purpose as the Redeemer ([17:30–31](#)). • As he did elsewhere in his own writings (see [1 Cor 15:33](#); [Titus 1:12](#)), Paul made use of the Greek poets. There are several points of connection in this sermon with the *Hymn to Zeus* by Cleanthes (about 315–240 BC). Paul was probably quoting Epimenides, who had declared about God, "In him we live and move and exist" (Epimenides, *Cretica*, about 600 BC). Paul also cited Aratus, a Stoic poet from Cilicia (about 315–240 BC), who had commented, "We are his offspring" (Aratus, *Phaenomena* 5). These allusions to their own poets established connections with his audience. Paul was then able to present the singular nature of God ([Acts 17:29](#)), and he stressed the coming judgment through Jesus Christ, whom God had raised from the dead. This message, while touching on Greek culture and philosophy, had a clear focus on Christ that presented the challenge of Christ to a cultured and intellectual but idolatrous people.

Acts 17:30

The idea of people's ignorance is carefully discussed both in the Old Testament law ([Lev 4:2, 22, 27](#); [5:15, 17](#); [Num 15:25, 27](#)) and in the New Testament ([Eph 4:18](#); [1 Pet 1:14](#); [2:15](#); [2 Pet 3:5, 8](#)). Paul was particularly fervent about combatting ignorance (see [Rom 10:13–15](#); [11:25](#); [1 Cor 10:1](#); [12:1](#); [2 Cor 1:8](#); [1 Thes 4:13](#)). The message of Good News overcomes ignorance and summons all who hear it to repent of their sins and turn to God (see [Acts 2:38](#)).

Acts 17:32

The Athenians listened carefully until Paul spoke of the resurrection of the dead ([17:31](#)); at that point some laughed or mocked, for the notion of resurrection was foolish to Greek ears (see [1 Cor 15:12-19](#)). Similarly, the Jews in Jerusalem later listened carefully to Paul until he mentioned God's acceptance of the Gentiles ([Acts 22:22](#)). These are examples of how the message of Good News can offend people because of their prejudices (see [1 Cor 1:20-25](#)).

Acts 17:34

some joined him and became believers: Paul's sermon was not without positive response. Two prominent converts are mentioned: Dionysius and Damaris. Luke often placed a man and a woman in juxtaposition (e.g., [5:1-11](#); [17:4, 12](#); [Luke 14:1-6](#); [15:3-10](#)). • Dionysius was a member of the council of the Areopagus, the highest governing body of Athens.

Acts 18:1

In Roman times, Greek political power in Achaia resided in Corinth, a prominent city-state and major commercial city. Corinth was notorious for its prostitution, immorality, and drunkenness (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, "Setting"). Paul invested much time and effort establishing a Christian community in Corinth (see study note on Acts 16:8).

Acts 18:1-17

Paul spent eighteen fruitful months preaching and teaching in Corinth, first in the synagogue and then next door in the house of Titius Justus ([18:1-11](#)). Then, in court, Paul won a significant victory over his enemies ([18:12-17](#)).

Acts 18:2-3

The edict of Claudius Caesar that had deported all Jews from Rome around AD 49 is mentioned by the Roman historian Suetonius (*Life of Claudius* 25). • Aquila and Priscilla became an outstanding husband-and-wife team in the early church. They

earned their living as tentmakers, as did Paul, who probably lived and worked with them during his year and a half in Corinth ([18:11](#); see [Rom 16:3-4](#); [1 Cor 16:19](#)). • just as he was: Paul would have been trained as a tentmaker as a young man. It was Jewish custom to provide sons with a manual trade, including young men who intended to become rabbis or other professionals.

Acts 18:4-6

Once again Paul followed his custom of preaching to the Jews first, and then reaching out to Gentiles after he met with rejection and opposition ([13:42-49](#); see [3:25-26](#); [26:20](#); [Rom 1:16](#); [2:10](#); [3:29, 30](#); [4:9-12](#)). • Paul probably wrote his letters to the Thessalonian Christians after Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia with a report of how things were going there (see [1 Thes 3:6](#); 2 Thessalonians Book Introduction, "Setting").

Acts 18:7

Titius Justus ("Titus the Just") was a Gentile who worshiped God (a "God-fearer"; see study note on 10:2). Because Titus was a common Roman name, *Justus* differentiates him from the better-known Titus, Paul's co-worker ([2 Cor 2:13](#); [7:6, 13](#); [8:6, 16, 23](#); Titus).

Acts 18:9-10

Paul had experienced real opposition in Corinth ([18:6](#)) and apparently was afraid of being attacked again, so the divine message was a comfort to him (cp. [23:11](#); [Ps 34:4, 7, 19](#); [Matt 28:20](#)), encouraging him to persist in his public ministry and promising God's protection (cp. [Ps 91:11](#); [2 Tim 4:17](#)).

Acts 18:12-13

The governor of Achaia, Junio Gallio, was the older brother of the Roman philosopher Seneca (Seneca was a tutor to Emperor Nero). An inscription indicating that he was governor around AD 51-52 helps to date Paul's visit in Corinth to about that time.

Acts 18:14–17

Gallio's ruling indicated that the charges against Paul were unjustified. The Roman government had nothing to fear from acknowledging Christianity as a legal religion.

Acts 18:17

It is most likely that the Greeks beat Sosthenes to express their hostility to the Jews; it is possible that the Jews attacked their own synagogue leader because he was unsuccessful in pleading their case. Sosthenes may be the same man Paul later mentions as "our brother" ([1 Cor 1:1](#)), but it is uncertain, as the name was fairly common.

Acts 18:18

Cenchrea was a seaport located on the Aegean Sea, roughly five miles (8 km) east of Corinth. It was here that Paul shaved his head according to Jewish custom to mark the completion of a temporary Nazirite vow (cp. [21:23–24](#); see [Num 6:1–21](#); [Judg 13:4–7](#); [16:1](#); [Amos 2:11–12](#); [Luke 1:15](#)).

Acts 18:19–23

Paul made a quick stop at Ephesus, the most important city in the Roman province of Asia. There he left the others behind, including Priscilla and Aquila ([18:26](#)). He sailed to Judea, landing at Caesarea, the headquarters of the Roman forces of occupation. After a visit to the church at Jerusalem, Paul returned to Antioch, the church that had originally commissioned him. This marked the end of his second missionary journey. In Antioch, he spent a rewarding time of reporting what God had done through him and his colleagues, sharing the excitement and challenges of their work with the home church. Then after . . . some time, Paul began his third missionary journey. He went by land rather than by sea, traveling through Galatia and Phrygia and revisiting believers whom he had led to faith in Christ on his previous trips. It was important to him that these young converts not be left to founder and shipwreck their faith (see [Eph 6:10–20](#); [1 Tim 1:18–20](#); [2 Tim 1:15](#); [4:10](#)).

Acts 18:21

"I will come back later": Paul later spent significant time in Ephesus during his third missionary journey ([19:1–20:1](#); see [19:8](#), [10](#)).

Acts 18:23

Paul wanted to keep in touch with earlier converts and strengthen their faith.

Acts 18:23–19:41

This section describes Paul's third missionary journey (about AD 53–57). Paul revisited Galatia and Phrygia, strengthening the disciples ([18:23](#)). He then traveled to Ephesus ([19:1](#)), where he remained for over two years ([19:8–10](#)).

Acts 18:24–26

Alexandria, the second-largest city in the Roman Empire, was famous for its rhetorical tradition and the philosophical work of Philo. Apollos was an eloquent speaker with an excellent knowledge of the Scriptures (the Old Testament). His knowledge about Jesus and the Holy Spirit was inadequate, though. He did not understand that believers could experience and enjoy the power of the Holy Spirit as a present energizing reality. Fortunately, Priscilla and Aquila took him aside and corrected his spiritual understanding.

Acts 19:1–7

Paul traveled to Ephesus after Apollos had left. Subsequently, Apollos returned to Ephesus while Paul was still working there ([1 Cor 16:12](#)). The two men had different personalities, gifts, and roles, but God worked through both of them. • Some believers in Ephesus still had an inadequate understanding of the Christian faith (cp. [Acts 18:26](#)) and did not receive the Holy Spirit when they believed. They had accepted John's baptism, which called for repentance from sin, but had not received Christian baptism, which included the gift of the Holy Spirit. When Paul had instructed them further, they were able to receive Christian baptism ([19:5](#)) and the Holy Spirit ([19:6](#)).

Acts 19:6

When Paul laid his hands on them they received the Holy Spirit, spoke in other tongues and prophesied, thereby experiencing the same filling with God's power and presence that the disciples had received on the day of Pentecost ([2:4](#), [11](#)).

Acts 19:10

Paul probably wrote 1 Corinthians during this time (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, "Date and Occasion of Writing").

Acts 19:11–12

Paul, like other Christian evangelists ([3:1–11](#); [4:22](#); [5:12–16](#); [6:8](#); [8:6–7](#), [13](#); [9:33–42](#)), performed unusual miracles. • evil spirits were expelled: As Jesus and Peter had done (cp. [5:16](#); [Mark 1:21–34](#); [Luke 4:31–37](#)).

Acts 19:13–16

Paul's effectiveness is contrasted with the impotence of the traveling Jewish exorcists, who used the name of Jesus as though it were magical but did not have a relationship with him or the indwelling power of the Holy Spirit (cp. [Matt 12:27](#); [Mark 9:38–39](#); [Luke 9:49–50](#); [11:19](#)).

Acts 19:17–19

The contrast between Paul and the Jewish exorcists was not lost on the people of Ephesus, Jews and Greeks alike. The resulting fear caused the inhabitants to honor and respect the name of the Lord Jesus. It led many to confess and forsake their sinful practices, including sorcery.

Acts 19:20

Luke's summary of the success of the Good News in Ephesus is short but pungent (cp. [2:43–47](#); [5:14](#); [6:7](#); [9:31](#); [12:24](#); [16:5](#); see [Rom 1:16](#)). When the Christian faith overcame problems of internal dissension, idolatry, and pagan practices, it spread widely and grew rapidly.

Acts 19:21–22

felt compelled by the Spirit: No doubt Paul was troubled by what he had heard about the situation in Corinth (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction). Instead of going immediately himself, he sent . . . Timothy, who was carrying a letter, 1 Corinthians, from Paul to the Corinthians ([1 Cor 4:17](#); [16:10–11](#)). Paul himself did go over to Macedonia and Achaia not long afterward ([Acts 20:1–3](#)). • "I must go on to Rome!": Perhaps compelled by his proven strategy (see study note on 16:8), Paul wanted to proclaim the Good News in the most significant city in the world.

Acts 19:23

the Way: See study note on 9:2.

Acts 19:23–41

The patron deity of Ephesus was the Greek goddess Artemis. Her birthplace was believed to be Ephesus, so Ephesus was the official guardian of the temple. Twice annually, elaborate festivals were held in her honor with athletic, musical, and theatrical celebrations that included singing Great is Artemis of the Ephesians! The temple of Artemis at Ephesus was one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. Conversions to Christianity clearly damaged the worship of Artemis and the associated economic activity, but it became clear that Paul and his associates had committed no crime.

Acts 19:24

Silver coins and shrines carrying the image of Artemis were minted in Ephesus; statuettes of the goddess were used in civic processions and are still sold there today.

Acts 19:24–34

Demetrius, a silversmith whose business was threatened by Paul's proclaiming faith in one God, whipped up a major riot against him.

Acts 19:27

all around the world: The ancient geographer Strabo reports that temples dedicated to Artemis existed in cities from Asia Minor (now Turkey) to what is now France and Spain (Strabo, *Geography* 3.4.8; 4.1.4).

Acts 19:29

Archaeologists have excavated the amphitheater where the whole city assembled; it held 24,000 people.

Acts 19:31

Some of the officials of the province (Greek Asiarchai, “rulers of Asia”): The “Asiarchs” were the appointed leaders in the Roman province of Asia. They served as civic benefactors and usually championed the emperor cult. Some of these officials in high places were friends of Paul—Luke highlights that Christianity was attractive to people of high standing in society.

Acts 19:35

The tradition that the image (statue) of Artemis had fallen from heaven might point to its having been carved from a meteor.

Acts 19:35–41

The demonstration was finally quelled only when the mayor intervened and dismissed the assembly to prevent the city from being charged by the Roman government with rioting. This story demonstrates that Christians in the Roman world were entitled to legal due process.

Acts 20:1–2

Paul traveled to Macedonia, where he encouraged the believers in all the towns, including Thessalonica, Philippi, and Berea. He also continued to gather the offering for the needy in Jerusalem (see [Rom 15:25–28](#); [2 Cor 8:1–9:15](#)). Titus met Paul in Macedonia with a report from Corinth, which prompted Paul to write 2

Corinthians and send Titus back carrying it ([2 Cor 7:5–7](#); [8:6](#)).

Acts 20:2–3

From Macedonia, Paul traveled down to Greece—i.e., Corinth in the province of Achaia (see study note on 18:1)—where he stayed for three months (cp. [2 Cor 13:1](#)). Paul probably wrote his letter to the Romans during this time (see Romans Book Introduction, “Date, Place, and Occasion of Writing”). • a plot . . . against his life: Cp. [Acts 9:23–25](#), [28–30](#); [23:12–35](#); [25:3](#).

Acts 20:4

Paul’s traveling companions were disciples from Berea, Thessalonica, Derbe, and Asia, whom he was mentoring and equipping to lead (cp. [2 Tim 2:2](#)).

Acts 20:5–15

This is another of the “we” passages in Acts (see study note on 16:10). Luke apparently rejoined Paul at Philippi, where Luke had remained several years earlier, and journeyed with Paul to Jerusalem ([21:1–18](#)).

Acts 20:7–12

On the first day of the week the early church commemorated Jesus’ resurrection (see [Mark 16:9](#); cp. [John 20:19](#); [Rev 1:10](#)). • This was Paul’s last visit to Troas, which included gathering to share in the Lord’s Supper. This meal probably included both communion and a common meal (cp. [Acts 2:42, 46](#); [Jude 1:12](#)). • The remarkable feature of this gathering was the understated miraculous restoration of Eutychus, the young man who fell asleep on a windowsill and dropped three stories to his death (cp. [Acts 9:36–41](#)).

Acts 20:13–15

Assos was a key city in Mysia on the east coast of the Aegean Sea. • Mitylene was the most strategic city on the island of Lesbos. • The island of Samos was of major importance on the trade routes from

Asia Minor to the west and from the Aegean Sea to Egypt.

Acts 20:16

The Festival of Pentecost was one of the three Jewish pilgrimage festivals (see study note on 2:1–4).

Acts 20:17

Miletus was a major port on the western coast of Asia Minor at the mouth of the Meander River. It provided a place for Paul to meet briefly with the elders of Ephesus on his way to Jerusalem.

Acts 20:18–38

Paul's address to the elders of the church of Ephesus is a testimony regarding his life and ministry in Ephesus, calling for similar dedication from the leaders who would carry on the ministry. The sermon highlights Paul's integrity and pastoral care ([20:18–21](#), [26](#), [31](#)), speaks about the future ([20:22–23](#), [25](#), [29–30](#)), warns against false teachers ([20:29–30](#)), and exhorts the elders to be watchful and faithful ([20:28](#), [31](#)). Paul modeled sacrificial, conscientious, servant leadership.

Acts 20:23

the Holy Spirit tells me: See, e.g., [21:10–12](#).

Acts 20:26

I have been faithful. If anyone suffers eternal death, it's not my fault: Cp. [Ezek 3:16–21](#).

Acts 20:28

Paul refers to the church as God's people and God's flock (cp. [1 Pet 2:25](#); [5:2](#), [4](#)). Elsewhere the church is called *the body of Christ* ([1 Cor 12:27](#); [Eph 1:23](#); [4:12](#); [Col 1:24](#)); the *bride of Christ* ([2 Cor 11:2](#); [Rev 19:7](#); see [Eph 5:25–32](#)); *the temple of the living God* ([1 Cor 3:16](#); [2 Cor 6:16](#)); *a chosen people, royal priests, a holy nation, God's very own possession* ([1](#)

[Pet 2:9](#)); and *God's field, God's building* ([1 Cor 3:9](#)).

• Paul expected the leaders to feed and shepherd the church over which the Holy Spirit had appointed them as leaders (see [1 Tim 3:1–7](#); [Titus 1:5–7](#); [1 Pet 5:1–4](#); cp. [Acts 6:2–4](#)).

Acts 20:29–30

vicious wolves: Paul's prophecy did in fact happen, prompting him to write to Timothy in Ephesus some five years later (see [1 Tim 1:3–7](#), [19–20](#); [4:1–5](#); see also [Matt 7:15](#); [10:16](#); [Mark 13:22](#); [Luke 10:3](#); [2 Pet 2:1–22](#); [3:3](#)).

Acts 20:35

'It is more blessed to give than to receive': This saying of Jesus is not recorded in the Gospels.

Acts 20:38

The poignancy of the occasion was heightened by awareness that they would never see him again ([20:25](#)).

Acts 21:1

Cos was an island in the Aegean Sea with a major trade port. • Rhodes is a large Aegean island that featured the Colossus, a huge statue 100 feet (30 meters) tall that once stood at the entrance to the city. In Paul's time, the statue lay where it had fallen during an earthquake over 200 years earlier; it would not be removed for another 600 years. • Patara was the major port of Lycia, located on the coast opposite Rhodes.

Acts 21:1–18

This "we" passage (see study notes on 16:10; 20:5–15) covers Paul's journey from Miletus to Jerusalem at the close of the third missionary journey.

Acts 21:2–3

Tyre was an important port in Phoenicia with a maritime empire of far-flung commercial interests (see [Isa 23](#); [Jer 25:15–38](#); [47](#); [Zech 9](#); [Matt 15:21–28](#); [Mark 7:24–31](#)).

Acts 21:4–6

The local believers at Tyre gave Paul a touching farewell that reveals deep Christian fellowship. • prophesied through the Holy Spirit that Paul should not go on to Jerusalem: The believers at Tyre clearly foresaw the danger in Paul's visiting Jerusalem and out of brotherly concern tried to dissuade him. Paul willingly accepted the risks in order to fulfill his apostolic mandate (cp. [Phil 3:7–10](#)). See also study note on Acts 21:11–14.

Acts 21:7

Paul visited Ptolemais, an important city on the coast of the Mediterranean, as he made his way from Tyre to Caesarea.

Acts 21:8

Philip had the title of Evangelist due to his evangelistic activity ([8:4–40](#); cp. [Eph 4:11](#); [2 Tim 4:5](#)).

Acts 21:9

Philip's daughters' gift of prophecy demonstrated the fulfillment of Joel's prophecy, as Peter had preached at Pentecost ([2:17–21](#); [Joel 2:28–32](#)).

Acts 21:10

Luke juxtaposes female prophets ([21:9](#)) with a male prophet (see study note on 17:34). Agabus, like the Old Testament prophets, used symbolic actions to proclaim his message (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note).

Acts 21:11–14

Despite Agabus's prediction of suffering and the believers' begging Paul not to go to Jerusalem, Paul was resolutely ready even to die for the sake of the Lord Jesus. Luke stresses Paul's courage, determination, and heroism as a Christian missionary who would let nothing interfere with his mission. See study note on 21:4–6.

Acts 21:18–19

It was important for James and all the elders of the Jerusalem church to hear of Paul's successful mission among the Gentiles and for the mother church to continue to endorse this effort ([21:20](#); see [15:7–21](#)). Paul's report communicated that God had accomplished his purposes among the Gentiles through Paul's ministry.

Acts 21:20–25

The Jerusalem church leaders urged Paul to strengthen his credibility by demonstrating that he was not teaching Jews to turn their backs on the laws of Moses. At the same time, no attempt was made to force Jewish rules on Gentile converts—those terms had been set previously ([15:22–29](#)) and were simply to be honored.

Acts 21:26–36

The concerns of the Christian leaders ([21:20–25](#)) were evidently well based, for when their vows were almost completed, some Jews from the province of Asia raised a mob against Paul with false charges. They were intent on killing Paul, but the Roman commander rescued him.

Acts 21:28–29

Gentiles: It was a crime punishable by death to bring any non-Jew into the Temple precincts beyond the Court of the Gentiles (see also Josephus, *War* 5.5.2; 6.2.4). The Jews assumed that Paul had violated this sacred law by bringing Trophimus, a Gentile from Ephesus (see also [Acts 20:4](#); [2 Tim 4:20](#)), into the forbidden area.

Acts 21:30

This supposed desecration of the Temple aroused the fury of the Jewish populace. The Temple . . . gates were closed because they thought the Temple had been defiled by a Gentile.

Acts 21:31

commander: Or *tribune*, a Roman officer who commanded 1,000 men.

Acts 21:34

The fortress of Antonia, a large military garrison built by Herod the Great on the northwest corner of the Temple Mount, accommodated the Roman cohort that was stationed there to keep the peace.

Acts 21:37-40

The commander had mistaken Paul for an Egyptian false messiah who had planned to seize power from the Romans around AD 54 (roughly three years earlier; see Josephus, *War* 2.13.5). Paul corrected the mistake, gained permission to speak to the people, and addressed the crowd in Aramaic, the common language of Judea. He gave a strong statement of his faith in Jesus as the Messiah ([Acts 22:1-21](#)).

Acts 22:1-21

Paul's premier defense of his life and faith before his own people in Jerusalem illustrates his flexibility as a missionary, just as his speech to the Greek philosophers in Athens had done ([17:22-31](#); see [1 Cor 9:20-23](#)). Paul begins by recognizing his kinship with his people, explaining his Jewish background and training under the noted rabbi Gamaliel the Elder and describing his zealous desire to honor God in everything, which they shared ([Acts 22:1-3](#)). Paul then describes his persecution of Christians ([22:4-5](#)), the revelation of Jesus to him on the way to Damascus ([22:6-10](#)), and his conversion ([22:11-16](#)). Paul ends his speech by describing his conversation with the Lord in the Temple. The Lord had predicted the Jews' rejection of the message and had sent Paul to the Gentiles ([22:17-21](#)).

Acts 22:3

under Gamaliel: See study note on 5:34.

Acts 22:12-16

Ananias: See study note on 9:17.

Acts 22:14

the Righteous One: See also [3:14](#); [7:52](#); [1 Jn 2:1](#). Righteousness was one of the Messiah's characteristics (see [Isa 32:1](#); [53:11](#)).

Acts 22:16

be baptized. Have your sins washed away: See "Baptism" Theme Note.

Acts 22:17-22

While Paul was praying in the Temple, he saw a vision of Jesus telling him that the people of Jerusalem would not accept his testimony. The Lord then sent him to the Gentiles. The crowd's response to this report ([22:22-23](#)) proved the point.

Acts 22:23

The crowd's yelling, throwing off their coats, and tossing handfuls of dust into the air were probably ritual responses to perceived blasphemy. They opposed and tried to thwart Paul's words that suggested the inclusion of Gentiles ([22:21](#)). Cp. [Luke 4:16-30](#).

Acts 22:25-29

Paul claimed his status as a Roman citizen at this critical time when he was about to be tortured to make him confess his supposed crime. Roman citizenship was a valuable asset, and claiming it falsely was a capital offense. Its principal benefits were the prohibition of scourging and the right to appeal to the emperor ([25:11](#)). The commander

was frightened at having nearly violated Roman law (cp. [16:35-39](#)).

Acts 22:28

it cost me plenty! During the early part of the reign of Emperor Claudius (AD 41–54), Roman citizenship could be purchased, but it was expensive.

Acts 23:1

In addressing the high council, Paul insisted on his personal integrity before God—he had not violated God’s law or done the things they accused him of doing.

Acts 23:2

Ananias was the Jewish high priest from AD 47 to 58. • slap him: He apparently assumed that Paul was lying and tried to intimidate him.

Acts 23:3

you corrupt hypocrite: Cp. [Ezek 13:10-17](#); [Matt 23:27](#).

Acts 23:5

Why Paul did not recognize the high priest is not known. • Paul replied by quoting [Exod 22:28](#), acknowledging the respect to which the high priest was entitled by virtue of his office.

Acts 23:6

Paul focused on the key issue in his trial, the hope of resurrection from the dead. His preaching was simply the outworking of that hope and the fact of Jesus’ resurrection, but the message was unacceptable to both groups of Jews because of its implications. Pharisees could not abide the inclusion of the Gentiles apart from circumcision and keeping the law of Moses (cp. [15:5](#)), but that was what the resurrection of Jesus and the outpouring of the Spirit had provided ([Acts 2:39](#);

[10:34-48](#)). Sadducees could not stand the proclamation of the resurrection at all (cp. [4:1-2](#)).

Acts 23:7-10

Paul’s statement ([23:6](#)) divided the council, with the Pharisees taking Paul’s side against the Sadducees. The resulting uproar was so great that the commander rescued Paul and took him back into the fortress of Antonia.

Acts 23:11

At this critical juncture, Jesus encouraged Paul to continue as his faithful witness by assuring him that he would go to Rome (see [19:21](#)).

Acts 23:12-15

The plan to kill Paul was desperate, as a group of . . . more than forty took an oath not to eat or drink until they had killed Paul (cp. [1 Sam 14:24-46](#); [Matt 14:6-11](#); see also [Deut 23:21-23](#); [Matt 5:33-37](#); [Jas 5:12](#)).

Acts 23:16-22

Paul’s nephew thwarted the murderous plot by reporting it to one of the Roman officers.

Acts 23:23-35

A mounted escort took Paul safely to the Roman Governor Felix in Caesarea, the Roman headquarters for Judea. There Paul would have greater protection than in Jerusalem. The military operation was executed that night with secret efficiency and maximum security ([23:31](#)).

Acts 23:24

Antonius Felix was procurator (Governor) of Judea about AD 52–59, with responsibility for both military and civil affairs. Felix had a bad reputation (see [24:24-27](#)) and was eventually recalled to Rome by Nero.

Acts 23:26–30

The letter of Claudius Lysias to Governor Felix is a typical Hellenistic letter, naming the writer and the person addressed, offering a greeting, and stating the business at hand (though there is no parting word of farewell; see study note on 15:29). It summarizes the events that preceded it and explains the action taken; it also suggests that the commander has followed proper Roman judicial procedure. • The title his Excellency was often applied to persons of high social, political, or economic status ([Luke 1:3](#)).

Acts 23:31

Antipatris, a city rebuilt by Herod the Great in 9 BC on the Plain of Sharon, was a convenient military control point between Jerusalem and Caesarea.

Acts 23:35

The governor followed the proper protocol and waited for Paul's accusers to arrive before granting an official hearing. • Herod's headquarters was Herod the Great's palace at Caesarea; it subsequently became the residence of the Roman governors of Judea.

Acts 24:1–4

Tertullus presented the case for the prosecution, beginning with the customary speech of praise intended to attract the attention and sympathy of the governor, followed by the statement of charges ([24:5–8](#)).

Acts 24:1–27

Tertullus presented a legal case against Paul in a Roman court on behalf of the high priest ([24:1–9](#)). Then Paul cheerfully made his defense and defended his faith ([24:10–21](#)), and the governor adjourned the hearing without a decision and left Paul in prison for two years ([24:22–27](#)).

Acts 24:5

Troublemaker (or *agitator*) was a charge of political sedition. A Roman court would have taken this charge very seriously (see [16:21](#); [17:7](#); [18:13](#)). Similar accusations were made against Jesus before Pilate ([Luke 23:2, 5, 14](#)). • The term cult (or *party*, or *sect*) is used here in a negative sense to put Paul's religion under a pallor of suspicion if not illegality (see also [Acts 24:14](#)).

Acts 24:6

trying to desecrate the Temple: See study note on 21:28–29.

Acts 24:10–21

Paul's defense was that (1) he wasn't in Jerusalem long enough to incite a riot; (2) none of his accusers had ever seen him stirring up a riot; and (3) he worshiped in accord with Jewish law and everything written in the prophets.

Acts 24:14

the Way: See study note on 9:2. • Paul emphasized his common ground with his Jewish audience, including his worship, belief in the Jewish law, acceptance of the prophets, and hope in the resurrection ([24:14, 15](#); see [24:21](#)).

Acts 24:15

At the last judgment God will raise both the righteous and the unrighteous. Paul kept this final appointment with God constantly in mind ([24:16](#)). The fear of the "coming day of judgment" unnerved Felix in a subsequent conversation with Paul ([24:25](#)).

Acts 24:16

Paul stressed that he had acted with a clear conscience (see [20:27, 33](#); [23:1](#); [1 Cor 4:4](#); [2 Cor 1:12](#); [4:2](#); see also [2 Tim 1:3](#)). He had not departed from his Jewish heritage ([Acts 24:14](#)), and he had no fear of God's judgment ([24:15](#)).

Acts 24:17

money to aid my people: See study note on 20:1–2; see also [Rom 15:25–29](#); [1 Cor 16:1–2](#); [2 Cor 9:1–7](#).
 • and to offer sacrifices to God: See [Acts 21:23–26](#).

Acts 24:22

Perhaps Felix delayed his decision hoping that Paul would bribe him ([24:26](#)).

Acts 24:23

It was in keeping with the proper treatment of a Roman citizen to give him some freedom and allow his friends to visit him and take care of his needs.

Acts 24:24

Drusilla was the sister of Herod Agrippa II and Bernice ([25:13](#)); Drusilla had abandoned her former husband, Azizus the King of Emessa, and married Felix. Drusilla was Jewish, so in forsaking her original husband and marrying Felix she had disregarded God's commands ([Exod 20:14](#); [Deut 5:18](#); cp. [Mal 2:16](#); [Mark 10:12](#)). Josephus criticized her for this (*Antiquities* 20.7.1–2). Drusilla and her husband were confronted in their conversation with Paul by the prospect of judgment.

Acts 24:25

Paul's words about righteousness, self-control, and coming divine judgment frightened Felix, who was notably corrupt ([24:26–27](#); see study notes on 23:24; 24:24).

Acts 24:26–27

Felix kept Paul in custody hoping for a bribe. When this failed and his own term ended, he left Paul in prison to gain favor with the Jewish people.

Acts 24:27–25.5

Felix's successor was Porcius Festus, appointed by Nero to be governor of Judea about AD 59~62. Josephus describes Festus as a conscientious, honest administrator who was not able to stem the rising tide of Jewish unrest despite his strong action against the party of the Assassins (Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.8.10; cp. [Acts 21:38](#)). He resisted the Jewish leaders' attempt to have Paul's trial moved to Jerusalem, but he was not immune to their pressure ([25:9](#)).

Acts 25:7

The serious accusations were probably those raised previously ([21:27–28](#); [24:5–9](#)), but the accusations were unsupported by the evidence ([24:10–13](#)).

Acts 25:9

Festus, wanting to please the Jews: The governor would later state his official reason for delaying Paul's trial and asking to move it to Jerusalem ([25:17–20](#)). His request was driven by politics, however, not justice.

Acts 25:10–11

Festus's suggestion that Paul be tried in Jerusalem motivated the apostle's appeal to Caesar. Paul was not afraid of death, but he objected to being turned over to a biased court intent on murder, not justice ([25:7](#)).

Acts 25:12

Festus granted Paul's appeal. This fulfilled Paul's conviction that he must see Rome ([19:21](#); see also [23:11](#); [27:24](#); [Rom 1:13–15](#); [15:22–29](#)).

Acts 25:13–22

Festus discussed Paul's case with Herod Agrippa II (ruled AD 50–100), who had come to Caesarea to make a courtesy call on the new governor.

Acts 25:16

It was a fundamental principle: Roman law did not convict people without a trial. They must be given an opportunity to confront their accusers and defend themselves (cp. [19:38–39](#)). This put Roman judicial procedure in a favorable light for readers of Acts.

Acts 25:17

I didn't delay: In contrast with Felix, his predecessor ([24:22–27](#)).

Acts 25:18–20

These verses give Festus's official reasons for his actions; see also [25:9](#). There were no criminal accusations against Paul; the objections were about their religion and centered on Paul's claim that Jesus . . . is alive.

Acts 25:23–27

Paul's hearing before King Agrippa was accompanied by all the pomp and circumstance appropriate for an official royal visit. The main purpose of the hearing was for Agrippa to advise Festus on what he should write in the appeal to Caesar, for there was no clear charge against Paul, and Festus himself believed Paul had done nothing deserving death.

Acts 26:1–23

In his eloquent defense before King Agrippa, Paul argued that his preaching was completely consistent with the Jewish faith. The defense begins with a courteous acknowledgement of Agrippa's competence to hear the evidence ([26:2–3](#)), outlines the nature of Paul's background, Jewish training, and membership in the Pharisees ([26:4–5](#)), and explains that the charges against him are merely for believing the fulfillment of Jewish hopes for the resurrection ([26:6–8](#)). Paul then tells the story of his conversion from strong opponent of Christianity ([26:9–11](#)) through a vision on the way to Damascus ([26:12–18](#); see [9:1–18](#)). His preaching was nothing more than obeying this divine vision ([26:19–20](#)). Even though he encountered violent

opposition from his fellow Jews ([26:21](#)), God protected him as he taught a message that the Jews should have embraced ([26:22–23](#)). This defense is a model for Christians put on trial for their faith (see [9:15](#); [Luke 21:12–15](#)).

Acts 26:12–18

See [9:1–18](#).

Acts 26:17–18

Throughout his defense in this trial for his life, Paul also clearly set out the conditions for receiving new life in Christ (also in [26:20](#), [23](#); see [Matt 10:19–20](#)).

Acts 26:22–23

Paul stressed God's protection as he carried out his witness (cp. [3:18](#); [10:43](#); [Luke 24:25–27](#), [44–47](#)). Paul then called on his hearers to believe his message, that Jesus is the Messiah who fulfills the promises of the Old Testament (see [Luke 24:27](#), [44](#)).

Acts 26:24

Paul, you are insane: Festus, a Roman, thought all this talk about the prophets and resurrection was crazy (cp. [17:18](#), [32](#)), and he concluded that Paul must have driven himself mad with too much study.

Acts 26:26

they were not done in a corner: The major events of the Christian faith were historical matters of public record that witnesses could attest as factually true. Agrippa could not invalidate Paul's statements of fact.

Acts 26:27–28

Paul's question put Agrippa in a bind: If he said he believed the prophets, he knew Paul would press home the Christian message; if not, he would offend the devout Jews in his audience. Agrippa knew that

Paul wasn't crazy and that Paul's testimony about Jesus was historically sound ([26:26](#)). So Agrippa evaded Paul's question and refused to face the claims of Christ, alleging that the statement given by Paul was too brief for him to arrive at a responsible decision.

Acts 26:28

"Do you think you can persuade me to become a Christian so quickly?": This enigmatic remark might have been ironic, incredulous, scoffing, or brushing off Paul's challenge. It also might have been a direct statement of Paul's persuasiveness, or a direct statement about or genuine question of Paul's intention. It seems best to take Agrippa's reply as deliberately evasive: He didn't want to admit that he believed the prophets ([26:27](#)), for Paul had just made a strong case, and the next step would be to believe in Jesus as the promised Messiah to whom the prophets pointed. Agrippa didn't want to take that step. On the other hand, he didn't want to say that he didn't believe the prophets, for that would alienate the Jewish subjects to whose loyalties he wanted to appeal. His non-committal response underlines his discomfort with Paul's testimony.

Acts 26:29

Paul's bold answer shows his quickness in repartee. He challenges Agrippa and his whole audience about the value of knowing Christ and making a personal commitment to him.

Acts 26:31

The consensus of these rulers was that Paul had not done anything to deserve death or imprisonment; this verdict was given repeatedly by the Roman authorities that considered Paul's case ([25:25](#); see [Luke 23:4, 15, 22](#)).

Acts 26:32

He could have been set free: The legal verdict was clear ([26:31](#)). But as a practical matter, if he hadn't appealed to Caesar, Paul might not have been alive ([25:1-11](#)). As it was, he was fulfilling God's purposes for him ([23:11](#)).

Acts 27:1

Julius is otherwise unknown. • The Imperial Regiment (see study note on [10:1-8](#)) served in Syria during this time.

Acts 27:1-28.16

The vivid nautical language used throughout the account of Paul's journey to Rome yields one of the best available accounts of an ancient sea voyage. • This is the last "we" section in Acts (see also [16:10-17](#); [20:5-15](#); [21:1-18](#)). During the two years of Paul's imprisonment, Luke had probably done much of the research for his Gospel throughout Judea and Galilee. Here, as a member of Paul's sailing party, he was an eyewitness participant in the danger at sea.

Acts 27:2

Aristarchus was a native of Thessalonica and a co-worker with Paul in Asia (see [19:29](#); [20:4, 6](#); [Phlm 1:24](#)). • Adramyttium was a port on the west coast of Asia Minor southeast of Troas.

Acts 27:3

Sidon, on the coast about 70 miles (110 km) north of Caesarea, was the first port of call. Julius treated Paul kindly and allowed his local Christian friends to care for him.

Acts 27:4-6

Luke describes in detail the sea voyage north and then west along the southern coast of Asia Minor. • Myra was a regular stop for Egyptian grain ships bound for Italy.

Acts 27:7

The great difficulty was due in part to the lateness of the season ([27:9](#)). • Cnidus was a seaport on the southwestern coast of Asia Minor near the island of Cos. • The cape of Salmone was located at the

northeastern tip of Crete, the largest of the Greek islands.

Acts 27:8

Fair Havens was a small bay on the southern side of the island of Crete.

Acts 27:9

because it was so late in the fall: This was a dangerous time for a voyage on the Mediterranean.

Acts 27:10-11

Paul realized what would happen if they went on. He warned the ship's officers, but they and the Roman officer were unlikely to listen to an imprisoned Jewish rabbi with no experience as a seaman. Later, however, they would respect him more ([27:30-36](#), [42-43](#)).

Acts 27:12

The prevailing southeasterly winds made Fair Havens an unsafe place for ships to harbor in the winter, but Phoenix, a town farther up the coast of Crete, offered a better harbor.

Acts 27:14-16

The storm, called a "northeaster," was of typhoon strength, very threatening to both the cargo and the crew. Forced to let the ship run before the gale, they sailed past a small island called Cauda (known today as *Gaudos*), south of Crete.

Acts 27:17

- The purpose of wrapping ropes around the ship's framework (hull) was to strengthen it against the storm's pressure. This process is called *frapping*.
- *Syrtis* refers to the shallow bays with *sandbars* off the North African coast, west of Cyrene.

Acts 27:18-20

The violence and persistence of the storm led to throwing the cargo overboard (cp. [Jon 1:5](#)) and the crew's abandoning hope.

Acts 27:21-26

Paul addressed the crew, first scolding them for not listening to him ([27:10-12](#)) and then encouraging them with the angel's assurance of survival for all of them.

Acts 27:27

The Sea of Adria, south of Italy and Greece and between Malta and Crete, is now known as the Ionian Sea.

Acts 27:30-32

This time the soldiers listened to Paul (cp. [27:10-11](#)).

Acts 27:33-35

Paul's words and actions are those of a true leader who personally assesses a perilous situation, decides on action, and leads others in solving the problem (cp. [Neh 1-3](#); contrast [Jon 1](#)). Paul's positive example and strong faith in God ([Acts 27:22-25](#)) encouraged the others to eat and take heart.

Acts 27:36–37

The food brought renewed strength and encouragement to the frightened and exhausted crew and prisoners. • all 276 of us: The exact number of persons onboard fits well with what is known of grain ships of the period.

Acts 27:39–41

They ran the ship aground on a shoal or reef.

Acts 27:42–44

Even in a crisis, the prisoners remained the responsibility of the soldiers (see [12:19](#); [16:27](#); [27:32](#); see study note on 16:27). Fortunately, the commanding officer intervened on their behalf. It was a clear indication of God's protection and favor that all 276 people made it safely to shore, precisely fulfilling the angel's promise (see [27:24](#)).

Acts 28:1

Malta was a major island under Roman control, about sixty miles (100 km) south of Sicily.

Acts 28:3–6

The locals of Malta understood justice as a personified power or deity carrying out judgment on a criminal. When nothing bad happened to Paul, the natives understood him as having power over snakes and concluded that he himself was a god (cp. [14:11–12](#)). In fact, Paul's survival demonstrated God's protection (cp. [Mark 16:17–18](#)).

Acts 28:8–9

Cp. [Luke 4:38–40](#).

Acts 28:10

Showing their gratefulness, the people supplied the ship's company with what they needed.

Acts 28:11

Another Egyptian ship from Alexandria took Paul and his companions on board after an interval of three months and the worst of the winter had passed.

Acts 28:11–16

Luke, himself present on this journey (see study note on 27:1–28:16), recorded Paul's itinerary from Malta to Rome with great geographical detail.

Acts 28:12

Syracuse was the capital of the eastern half of Sicily.

Acts 28:13–14

They sailed across the Straits of Messina to Rhegium on the southern tip of Italy. This port was a stopping place for ships traveling from the west coast of Italy to the eastern Mediterranean. • Puteoli (modern Pozzuoli) was a major port of entry for large grain ships bringing supplies from the east to Rome. Paul spent a week here with some local believers before moving on to Rome.

Acts 28:15

Paul was greeted by brothers and sisters who met his party on the way up to Rome.

Acts 28:16

Paul was allowed to have his own . . . lodging, apparently in private facilities, though he was guarded by a soldier. Though Paul was traveling in chains, "the word of God cannot be chained" ([2 Tim 2:9](#)). Paul was possibly treated so well because of his social status or Roman citizenship (cp. [Acts 16:37–38](#); [22:25–28](#)).

Acts 28:17–20

Conscious that the Good News was to be presented to the Jews first ([13:46](#); [Rom 1:16](#)) and concerned that the false charges against him might already

have reached Rome, Paul summoned the local Jewish leaders and gave an account of his life and work. He insisted that he was guilty of no criminal offense, but strong Jewish opposition had made it necessary for him to appeal to the emperor. Paul had nothing against his own people; rather, he wanted to explain his great conviction that the Messiah they had been expecting had already come in the person of Jesus of Nazareth.

Acts 28:21–22

The Jewish leaders assured Paul that they had received no reports against him, and they wanted to hear his explanation of this movement.

Acts 28:23

Paul explained how Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament hopes for the Kingdom of God, the master theme of Jesus' own preaching ([Mark 1:14–15](#); see [Matt 4:12–17](#); [Luke 4:14–21, 43](#)). Referring to the Scriptures, Paul presented the case for Jesus as the promised Messiah.

Acts 28:24

Paul's all-day message met a mixed response, as it had in other quarters (e.g., [13:40–51](#); [17:11–14](#)).

Acts 28:25–28

Paul parted with scriptural words of warning that are often used in the New Testament to explain the Jewish rejection of the gospel (cp. [Matt 13:14–15](#); [Mark 4:12](#); [Luke 8:10](#); [John 12:38–40](#); see [Rom 11:1–12, 25–32](#)).

Acts 28:28

Since Jews everywhere had been given an opportunity to accept the faith ([13:46](#); see [Rom 1:16](#)), it was now time for the Gentiles to be offered this salvation.

Acts 28:31

Despite being under house arrest ([28:16](#)), Paul boldly proclaimed the Kingdom message. • And no one tried to stop him (Greek *akōlutōs*, “without hindrance”): This single word in Greek is the last word of the book of Acts and one of the keys to its meaning: God's word cannot be chained, even when its messengers are ([2 Tim 2:9](#); see [Phil 1:12–14](#)). Acts is the story of an unhindered message of Good News, available to all people throughout the world, whether Jew, Gentile, proselyte, rich, or poor. The mission of proclaiming this message is accomplished in the power of the Spirit ([Acts 1:8](#)); it embraces Jews ([3:1–5:42](#)), Samaritans ([8:1–25](#)), converts to Judaism ([2:11](#); [13:43](#)), “God-fearers” ([8:26–40](#); [9:32–11:18](#)), and Gentiles ([13:1–28:28](#)). • Luke ends his account with Paul still under house arrest in Rome (about AD 60–62). Paul was later released and traveled freely. According to tradition, Paul was imprisoned again in Rome about AD 64 and was martyred there during Nero's persecution of believers.